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# Notes on al-Battānī's *Zīj*

from *Al-Battānī sive Albatenii Opus astronomicum* (Milan, 1899–1907)

translated from the Latin

Nallino's edition of al-Battānī's *Zīj* gives the Arabic text (Part III, 1899), a Latin translation of the canons with a commentary on them (Part I, 1903), and the tables in Latin with notes on them, a glossary and indexes (Part II, 1907). The canons themselves are translated into English from the Arabic in the English *Zīj* of this edition; this volume translates Nallino's own writing, which is in Latin and has not been translated before. It is made from the line-by-line transcription of his Latin in this edition (S03 and S04). Every sentence is translated, in Nallino's order; nothing is summarised or left out. His Arabic, Greek and Hebrew quotations stand in their scripts, as he prints them, with his translations of them in English. Proper names are given in a modern transliteration. In the headings of the commentary, «p.» and «l.» are the pages and lines of Nallino's Latin translation (Part I, pp. 1–150); «t. III» is the Arabic text, whose pages the English *Zīj* gives in its margin. Nallino's footnotes are numbered; the few notes of the translator are lettered. Nallino's own corrections in the «Addenda et emendanda» of Part II are followed and noted. The pages of Nallino's volumes are given in the margin.

The translation is in progress. This version holds the commentary on chapter 3, the commentary on chapter 4, the commentary on chapter 5, the commentary on chapter 6. It is AI-translated (Claude), 2026; no person has proofread it. Nallino's work is in the public domain; the translation is dedicated to the public domain (CC0 1.0).

# Commentary

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## On chapter 3

**a)** — pp. 9–10.

All the propositions on *chords* that the author gives are proved in the *Almagest* I, 9 (ed. Halma, vol. I, pp. 26–37). If we denote the radius by the letter R, they are expressed in our algebraic notation as follows:

(α) $\operatorname{chord}\frac{360^\circ}{6}$ or $\operatorname{chord} 60^\circ = R$

(β) $\operatorname{chord}\frac{360^\circ}{3}$ or $\operatorname{chord} 120^\circ = \sqrt{4R^2 - \operatorname{chord}^2\frac{360^\circ}{6}}$

(γ) $\operatorname{chord}(180^\circ - a) = \sqrt{4R^2 - \operatorname{chord}^2 a}$

(δ) $\operatorname{chord}\frac{360^\circ}{4}$ or $\operatorname{chord} 90^\circ = \sqrt{2R^2}$

(ε)[a] $\operatorname{chord}\frac{360^\circ}{10}$ or $\operatorname{chord} 36^\circ = \sqrt{R^2 + \left(\frac{2R}{4}\right)^2} - \frac{2R}{4}$

(ζ) $\operatorname{chord}\frac{360^\circ}{5}$ or $\operatorname{chord} 72^\circ = \sqrt{\operatorname{chord}^2\frac{360^\circ}{10} + R^2}$

(η) $\operatorname{chord}(a-b) = \frac{\operatorname{chord} a \operatorname{chord}(180^\circ - b) - \operatorname{chord} b \operatorname{chord}(180^\circ - a)}{2R}$

(ϑ) $\operatorname{chord}\frac{a}{2} = \sqrt{\frac{2R - \operatorname{chord}(180^\circ - a)}{2} \times 2R}$

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To find the chord of the sum of two arcs, Ptolemy (ed. Halma, vol. I, pp. 32–33), whom our author follows, has nothing like the rule (η), but goes by way of the chord of the supplement[1]; hence

(ι)[b] $\operatorname{chord}(180^\circ - [a+b]) = \frac{\operatorname{chord}(180^\circ - a)\operatorname{chord}(180^\circ - b) - \operatorname{chord} a \operatorname{chord} b}{2R}$

(κ) $\operatorname{chord}(a+b) = \sqrt{4R^2 - \operatorname{chord}^2(180^\circ - [a+b])}$

Almost all the historians of mathematics describe the way by which Ptolemy came to compute the chord of 1°; of the most recent, one may consult M. Cantor, *Vorlesungen über Geschichte der Mathematik*, Leipzig 1880 ff., vol. I, pp. 353–355 (or 390–392 of the second edition, of 1894); R. Wolf, *Handbuch der Astronomie, ihrer Geschichte und Litteratur*, Zürich 1890–93, vol. I, pp. 164–165, § 61*b*; A. von Braunmühl, *Vorlesungen über Geschichte der Trigonometrie*, Leipzig 1900 ff., vol. I, p. 21. The error, which F. Woepcke determined with Lagrange's interpolation formula (*Discussion de deux méthodes arabes pour déterminer une valeur rapprochée de sin 1°*, in the Journal de Mathématiques pures et appliquées published by J. Liouville, vol. XIX, 1854, p. 165), is 0.00000009, that is, less than 1/10,000,000; it therefore becomes noticeable only in the thirds,

[1] Delambre, *Astron. ancienne*, vol. II, p. 39, is mistaken (as Schiaparelli points out to me) in ascribing to Ptolemy the rule

$$\operatorname{crd}(p+q) = \frac{\operatorname{crd} p \operatorname{crd}(180^\circ - q) + \operatorname{crd} q \operatorname{crd}(180^\circ - p)}{2R}.$$

[*Translator:* The print has – between the two products; Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part II, p. XXI) correct it to +, which gives the chord of the sum.]

which Ptolemy leaves out of his table of chords. — A value of the sine of 1° nearer the truth was found by Abū l-Wafāʾ (940–998), whose error shows only in the fifths, that is, in the ninth decimal place (sin 30′ = $0^p\,31'\,24''\,55'''\,54^{IV}\,55^{V}$ instead of $54^{V}\,47^{VI}\,16^{VII}$); see Woepcke, *Recherches sur l'histoire des sciences mathématiques chez les Orientaux*, in the Journal Asiatique, 5th series, vol. XV, 1860, pp. 286–303; Cantor, I, 641–642 (= 703 of the second edition); von Braunmühl, I, 56–57. — According to what Mīram Čelebī (d. 931 H = 1524–25) has handed down to us in his commentary on Ulugh Beg (in Sédillot's French translation, pp. 69–77, note), other, early Arabs, whose names are not known, carried Ptolemy's method through and found a value of the sine of 1° that exceeds the truth by less than 1/100,000,000; for the error is 37/416 (or about 1/11) of Ptolemy's error, since they make sin 1° = $1^p\,2'\,49''\,43'''\,13^{IV}\,5^{V}\,30^{VI}$ instead of $11^{IV}\,14^{V}\,44^{VI}$. But had they not deliberately neglected certain small fractions in their computations, they could have found a far better number, whose error would have been 1/64 of Ptolemy's. See Woepcke, *Discussion de deux méthodes* etc., pp. 155–157, 159–167. — Lastly, Ghiyāth al-Dīn[1] Jamshīd al-Kāshī, in whom other Arabs had probably gone before him, computed sin 1° = $1^p\,2'\,49''\,43'''\,11^{IV}$ correctly and most elegantly, by solving the equation of the trisection of the angle approximately, that is, by expanding the equation of the third degree in a series; his method, handed down to us by Mīram Čelebī, loc. cit., pp. 77–83, was explained by Woepcke, *Discussion*, pp. 167–176, 301–303. See also H. Hankel, *Zur Geschichte der Mathematik im Alterthum und Mittelalter*, Leipzig 1874, pp. 290–293; Cantor, I, 671–672 (= 737 of the second edition); von Braunmühl, I, 73–75.

**b**) — pp. 10–11.

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The technical word *jayb*, by which the Arabs denote the sine, al-Battānī never mentions, although it was already in common use at the beginning of the ninth century, as appears from the unpublished Latin translation of the astronomical work of Muḥammad ibn Mūsā al-Khwārizmī, made by Adelard of Bath in the twelfth century. For there the Arabic name *elgeib* is kept (with the Arabic article *al* or *el* put before it), and «*elgeib elmustewi* or plane» [*al-jayb al-mustawī*], that is, the right sine, and «*elgeib elmacus* or diminished»[2], that is, the versed sine, are named. Likewise Ḥabash, a contemporary of al-Battānī, always uses the word *jayb*. But our author would not take up the word, which is of foreign origin and wholly alien to Greek usage. Not a few historians of mathematics, then, and among the best, are wrong when they ascribe the use of the word *jayb* to our author and think that Plato of Tivoli brought the word *sinus* to Europe with his translations; of the more recent I shall cite only Hankel, p. 280; Wolf, *Handb. der Astron.*, I, 166, § 62*a*; Cantor, I, 632 (= 693 of the second edition), II, 101 and 249. The old Kaestner, however, had already corrected the error, *Geschichte der Mathematik*, Göttingen 1796, vol. I, p. 522; see now M. Koppe, *Die Behandlung der Logarithmen und der Sinus*, Programm des Andreas-Realgymnasium, Berlin 1893, p. 32; von Braunmühl, I, 50. — The word *sinus* occurs only once in Plato of Tivoli's translation: «si autem per has cordas [*sic*] versas arcus scire desideras, si chorda quam habueris minus 60 fuerit, eam de 60 minue, et residui arcum scito, quem de 90 minues, et quod remanserit, erit arcus *sinus* versi» («but if you wish to know the arcs from these versed chords: if the chord you have is less than 60, take it from 60 and find the arc of the remainder; take that from 90, and what remains will be the arc of the versed *sinus*»; fol. 7v of the Nuremberg edition; the passage corresponds to p. 11, ll. 28–30 of my translation). But, as von Braunmühl, I, 50, note 3, rightly judges, the word must be taken for a gloss of Regiomontanus that has crept into the text by mistake.

[1] Some indeed call him, wrongly, ʿAtāb al-Dīn, reading عتاب ʿAtāb for غياث Ghiyāth. He died about the year 840 H, 1436–37, as H. Suter, *Die Mathematiker und Astronomen der Araber*, Leipzig 1900, pp. 173–4, no. 429, rightly established; to his arguments one may add that the little work on finding the sine of 1° (which still survives in the Cairo Library) is already praised by Qāḍīzāde al-Rūmī, who died between 840 and 850 H, as Mīram Čelebī relates.

[2] Adelard's error; *maʿkūs* = versed, inverted. The passage was cited by Chasles, *Recherches sur l'astronomie ancienne*, in the Comptes rendus de l'Académie des Sciences, vol. XXIII, session of 2 November 1846, p. 850.

Since chords are hardly ever used in trigonometric computations, it is no wonder that al-Battānī called the halves of the chords of the double arcs by the name of chords; a similar usage is found among the Indians as early as the fourth century, of whom one reads the following in the notes of Burgess and Whitney on the book entitled *Sūrya-siddhānta*: «In this passage, the sine is called *jyārdha*, 'half-chord'; hereafter, however, that term does not once occur, but *jyā* 'chord' (literally 'bowstring') is itself employed, as are also its synonyms *jīvā*, *māurvikā*, to denote the sine. The usage of Albategnius is the same» (*Translation of the Sūrya-Siddhānta, a text-book of Hindu astronomy, by* E. Burgess, note on ch. II, verse 28, in the Journal of the American Oriental Society, vol. VI, New Haven 1860, p. 201). — Nor should it be passed over that among the Arabs the name of the whole *chord* too comes from the usage of the Indians, as the passage just quoted shows; among the Greeks the chord was called ὑποτείνουσα, «subtending», ἡ ἐν τῷ κύκλῳ εὐθεῖα, «the straight line in the circle», εὐθεῖα ἐν κύκλῳ μὴ διὰ τοῦ κέντρου οὖσα, «a straight line in the circle not passing through the centre», εὐθεῖα ἐλάττων τοῦ διαμέτρου, «a straight line smaller than the diameter».

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The origin of the technical word *jayb* was explained satisfactorily by Munk, whom F. Woepcke, *Essai sur la propagation des chiffres indiens*, in the Journal Asiatique, 6th series, vol. I, 1863, p. 478, note, and almost all later writers have followed. From the Indian word *jīvā*, chord and sine, which I mentioned a little above, the Arabs, who have no letter *v*, made *jīb* جيب; for the Sanskrit *j* is pronounced like the Arabic *j*. But since *jīb* has no meaning in Arabic, while the letters جيب can also be read *jayb* without any change to the writing (for in ordinary writing the small signs that show the true pronunciation of the vowels are almost always left out), the Arabs preferred this form of the name, which in their language means not only «the round opening of a garment through which a man's neck and head pass», but also «the fold or pocket made in a garment for carrying small things»; occasionally, but rarely, it also means a man's bosom itself. We have already seen that Adelard of Bath kept the Arabic name *elgeib* in his translations; but his contemporary Gerard of Cremona (1114–1187), in translating the astronomy written by Jābir ibn Aflaḥ, used the word *sinus*, which came into our languages by this route, as Koppe, loc. cit., rightly observed[1]. J. Ruska, *Zur Geschichte des «Sinus»* (in the Zeitschrift für Mathematik und Physik, vol. XL, Leipzig 1895, historisch-literarische Abtheilung, p. 128), cites two Syriac writers of the thirteenth century[2] in whom the technical word *jayb* is always rendered by the Syriac *ʿūbā* ܥܘܒܐ, which means a man's bosom; but he is wrong when he writes: «Die Uebersetzung durch *sinus* ist demnach als richtig durch die syrische Belege gesichert. Die verständigere Uebersetzung aber, welche einen Mann voraussetzt, dem der mathematische Inhalt und dessen klarer Ausdruck wichtiger ist als pedantische Wörtlichkeit, lautet natürlich *chorda* . . . . . Beide Uebersetzungen finden sich vor: die zweite, wie Koppe nachgewiesen hat, bei Plato von Tivoli» («The translation by *sinus* is thus confirmed as correct by the Syriac evidence. The more sensible translation, however, which presupposes a man to whom the mathematical content and its clear expression matter more than pedantic literalness, is of course *chorda* . . . . . Both translations occur: the second, as Koppe has shown, in Plato of Tivoli»). For Plato of Tivoli writes *chorda* not from any striving after a more rational translation (how foreign that was to him and to the other translators of his age, their translations show plainly enough everywhere), but because al-Battānī uses this very word.

That the Arab mathematicians learned from the Indians the terms unknown to the Greeks — the chord, the sine, the right sine (Sanskrit *kramajyā*), the versed sine (Sanskrit *utkramajyā*), the sagitta (Sanskrit *śara* or *ishu*) — can hardly be doubted. To this one may add what the Arab writers relate of the Indian book entitled *al-Sindhind* (that is, the Sanskrit *Brahma-sphuṭa-siddhānta*), which was brought to the caliph at Baghdad in the year 156 H, 773. When all this is weighed, the

[1] But from the fact that it was Gerard of Cremona, not Plato of Tivoli, who spread the use of this word among us, I do not see how Koppe can call into doubt the origin of the Arabic *jayb* that Munk explained.

[2] They belong, then, to a late age not only of Syriac but also of Arabic letters, and not, as von Braunmühl, I, 50, note 1, writes, «in den ersten Zeiten des Mittelalters», to the first times of the Middle Ages.

history of the trigonometric functions can be told as follows. The Indians, moved above all by their use of orthogonal projections (von Braunmühl, I, 31–32), used right and versed sines instead of the chords of the Greeks; they computed them for the twenty-fourth parts of the quadrant, that is, for every 3° 45′, taking a radius of 3438 minutes. Once they had received the first notion of sines from the Indians, and had come to know Ptolemy's books at about the same time, the Arabs rightly understood that it was more convenient and more exact to construct new sines by halving Ptolemy's chords (which are computed for every half degree and a radius of sixty parts). This had already been done before al-Battānī.

**c**) — p. 11.

The *interpolation* for finding the sines of arcs that fall between two consecutive arcs of the table is the same as the one found in Ptolemy for computing chords: the change of the sines and of the chords is taken to be proportional to the change of the arcs within the interval of the table, half a degree. What Cantor, I, 355 (= 392 of the second edition), writes of Ptolemy, «ein Beweis für diese angenommene Proportionalität in engem Bereiche ist dagegen nicht vorhanden» («a proof of this proportionality, assumed within a narrow range, is however not given»), may rightly be said also of al-Battānī, of Ḥabash (fol. 18v) and of the other Arabs. More exact interpolations they used only in constructing tables. — Tables of sines for every minute of the quadrant, computed by Ibn Yūnus, survive in the Arabic codex 5752 of the Royal Library of Berlin; Ulugh Beg also computed others.

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*Versed sines*, whose use the Indians knew before the Arabs, the author defines:

$$\text{versed sine } a = R - \cos a.$$

He thought it superfluous to construct a table of them, which on the other hand we find in Ḥabash. At the foot of the page two formulas are given; one is

(α) $\quad \cos a = \sqrt{R^2 - \sin^2 a},$

which follows from the theorem of Pythagoras and, with $R = 1$, corresponds to our familiar rule

$$\cos a = \sqrt{1 - \sin^2 a}.$$

The other,

(β) $\quad \sin \dfrac{90^\circ - a}{2} = \sqrt{30^p\,(R - \sin a)},$

comes from the rule of al-Battānī and of Ptolemy mentioned in note *a* (p. 153),

$$\text{chord } \frac{a}{2} = \sqrt{\frac{2R - \text{chord}\,(180^\circ - a)}{2} \times 2R},$$

which, when sines are put for chords and $R = 60^p$ is taken, becomes

$$\sin \frac{a}{2} = \sqrt{30^p\,(R - \cos a)}.$$

Why al-Battānī took the complement of *a* in place of *a*, I do not know.

## On chapter 4

**a**) — p. 12.

Of the Arabs who measured the *obliquity of the ecliptic* before the year 1000, Ibn Yūnus relates the following in the eleventh chapter of his work[1]: «Between Ptolemy and the authors of the *Tested Tables* (*al-mumtaḥan*) I know of no observations of the obliquity except one made a little after[2] the year 160 of the Hijra [which began on 18 October 776], whose author gives the obliquity as 23° 31′. As for the value found by the authors of the *Tested Tables*[3] in observations close to our own age: Yaḥyā ibn Abī Manṣūr, Sanad ibn ʿAlī, al-ʿAbbās ibn Saʿīd al-Jawharī and a group of learned and eminent men (وطايفة من اهل العلم والفضل) investigated it in [the quarter called] al-Shammāsiyya of the city of Baghdad, in the time of [the caliph] al-Maʾmūn, and found 23° 33′, as Muḥammad ibn Mūsā al-Khwārizmī in his astronomical work (في زيجه) and Muḥammad ibn Kathīr al-Farghānī in his book on the making of the astrolabe report on their authority; and the matter is well known[4]. Those who observed at Damascus after the death of Yaḥyā ibn Abī Manṣūr, with the instrument that al-Maʾmūn had ordered to be made when he set out for the land of the Byzantines (بالالة التي امر باتخاذها المامون حين توجـه الى بـلاد الروم) — they are Khālid ibn ʿAbd al-Malik al-Marwarrūdhī, Abū l-Ṭayyib Sanad ibn ʿAlī, ʿAlī ibn ʿĪsā[a] al-Asṭurlābī and others — report that they found the greatest declination of the ecliptic to be 23° 33′ 52″; and the measurement made with this instrument was in the year 201 of Yazdajird» [which began on 27 April 832][5]. I 158

«Abū l-Ḥasan Thābit ibn Qurra says: I found ancient operations from before Ptolemy which show (تدل) that the greatest declination is 23° 35′[6]. Muḥammad ibn Jābir ibn Sinān al-Battānī relates that he found 23° 35′ by his observations. The noble and eminent Abū l-Qāsim ʿAlī ibn al-Ḥusayn ibn Muḥammad ibn ʿĪsā, known as Ibn al-Aʿlam, a man of learning and of outstanding intelligence, says that he measured the greatest declination and, taking the utmost care in the measurement, found 23° 34′ 2″. Abū l-Ḥasan al-Ṣūfī ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn ʿUmar relates that he measured the greatest declination and, having carried out the measurement with the greatest accuracy, found 23° 33′ 45″[7]; that man held an eminent place in the science of geometrical proofs. Help comes from God.»

Ibn Yūnus, ch. IV (in Caussin, p. 120), says that the value 23° 35′ was chosen in the *Tested Tables*; and al-Farghānī reports the same in ch. V (p. 20 of Golius's edition, fol. 121r of the Paris codex 2504). But Ibn Rusta, who copies the whole of this chapter of his contemporary al-Farghānī, has

[1] P. 222 of the Leiden codex (of which the Paris codex no. 2495 is a most careful copy, keeping the same division of the pages). I compared the passage with the Paris codex 2496 (which gives selected chapters of Ibn Yūnus's work and is written more carelessly), fol. 25r.

[2] What I have rendered «a little after» is in Arabic نيف, that is, «more than two but fewer than ten» [years after].

[3] This is the astronomical work that the astronomers of the caliph al-Maʾmūn (reigned 813–833) compiled from their observations under the direction of Yaḥyā ibn Abī Manṣūr.

[4] Ibn Yūnus himself confirms this in the introduction to his work (in Caussin, p. 56), saying that in the year 214 H (which began on 10 March 829), 198 of Yazdajird (which began on 28 April 829), Yaḥyā ibn Abī Manṣūr, al-ʿAbbās ibn Saʿīd al-Jawharī, Sanad ibn ʿAlī and others found 23° 33′ in the city of Baghdad. — Al-Zarqālī, in the unpublished Latin translation of the *Canons* or *Toledan Tables*, and the Jew Abraham ibn Ezra (in the second half of the twelfth century) say that Yaḥyā ibn Abī Manṣūr found 23° 33′ 30″; see Delambre, p. 177 (whose codex of the Toledan Tables gave the name in a corrupt form, «Almeon fils d'Albumazar»), and M. Steinschneider, *Études sur Zarkali*, in the Bullettino di bibliografia e di storia delle scienze matematiche e fisiche, vol. XX, 1887–88, p. 87 (where a codex of the Tables is cited that has the name «Jahiben filius Albumasaris»).

[5] He relates the same in the introduction (Caussin, 56); the year there is 217 H (which began on 7 February 832), 201 of Yazdajird.

[6] But in his own works Thābit chose 23° 33′, as appears from Ḥabash, fol. 90v, and Delambre, p. 73.

[7] The Paris codex 2496 wrongly writes 23. 35. 45. 38.

[a] The print has ʿAlī ibn Mūsā; Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part II, p. XXI) correct it to ʿAlī ibn ʿĪsā.

23° 33′ for 23° 35′[1]; and 23° 33′ is also read in the Latin translation of al-Farghānī made by John of Seville and printed at Nuremberg in 1537 (fol. 5r). This seems the more probable when one compares what Ibn Yūnus himself relates of the measurement made by the authors of the *Tested Tables*, and what Rabiçag of Toledo writes in his *Libro de las armellas*[2], which is drawn wholly from Arabic sources: «Et sabet que en este nuestro tiempo segund el nostro rectificar. bien se paresció por los rectificamentos antigos et los nuevos. que lo que ha entre ellos [that is, the interval between the pole of the ecliptic and the pole of the equator] non es uno todauia. Et esto es porque Abrachis [= Hipparchus] falló la declinacion que era .XXIII. grados et .LI. menudos. et falláronla los rectificadores [that is, the authors of the Tested Tables] en el tiempo de Memun Abdalla. fiio de Haron Arraxit .XXIII. grados et XXXIII. menudos. Et fallóla Mohamat. fiio de Aben el Bateni [= Muḥammad ibn Sinān al-Battānī] .XXIII. grados et .XXXV. menudos» («And know that in this our time, by our rectifying, it has appeared clearly from the ancient and the new rectifications that what lies between them is not always one. And this is because Abrachis found the declination to be 23 degrees and 51 minutes; and the rectifiers found it in the time of Memun Abdalla, son of Haron Arraxit, to be 23 degrees and 33 minutes; and Mohamat, son of Aben el Bateni, found it to be 23 degrees and 35 minutes»). — Thābit ibn Qurra says the same in the book *On the motion of the eighth sphere, or of access and recess*, which survives in two different Latin translations in the Vatican Library; one (cod. Lat. 4275, f. 84v, col. I) says: «Et eius [that is, of the whole obliquity] summa est 24 graduum secundum quod translatum est ab Indis, et similiter reperit Ptholomeus 23 g. et 51 minut., et consideratores [that is, اصحاب الممتحن, the authors of the Tested Tables] invenerunt in tempore Maymonis 23 g. et 33 m.» («and its amount is 24 degrees according to what has been handed down from the Indians, and likewise Ptolemy found 23 degrees and 51 minutes, and the observers found in the time of al-Maʾmūn 23 degrees and 33 minutes»); the other (cod. Lat. 4083, f. 56v, col. II): «pervenit talis declinatio ad 24 gradus secundum quod ab Indis traditum fuit. Ptolomeus quoque invenit eam 23 graduum et 51 mt. Alii autem inspectores post Ptolomeum in partem Mamonis eam 23 graduum 33 minutorum invenerunt»[a] («this declination reached 24 degrees according to what was handed down by the Indians. Ptolemy too found it to be 23 degrees and 51 minutes. But other observers after Ptolemy, on the side of al-Maʾmūn, found it to be 23 degrees 33 minutes»). — Lastly, it should not be passed over that Thābit ibn Qurra, as we saw in note 1, chose 23° 33′; and so did Qusṭā ibn Lūqā, who died about 910 or 912, in his book on the construction and use of the celestial globe[3]. — They would hardly have chosen 23° 33′ had they not found this value in the *Tested Tables*.

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Of those who flourished after the authors of the *Tested Tables*, down to the last years of al-Battānī, we know that the family of the Banū Mūsā[4], al-Nayrīzī[5] and the family of the Banū Amājūr[6] found the obliquity to be 23° 35′ by observation. So did, among later astronomers, Abū l-Wafāʾ, in the city of Baghdad, in the year 987 (on the evidence of Delambre, p. 156), and Ibn Yūnus in the year 391 H (which began on 30 November 1000; ch. XI, in Caussin, p. 238; more exactly he had found 23° 34′ 52″). — Many others adopted this obliquity of 23° 35′ in their tables, such as Ḥabash (a

[1]Ibn Rusta, *Kitâb al-Aʿlâk an-Nafisa VII*, edited by M. J. de Goeje, Leiden 1889, p. 16 [= Bibliotheca Geographorum Arabicorum, vol. VII].

[2]Book I, ch. IV = *Libros del saber de astronomia del Rey D. Alfonso X de Castilla, copilados, anotados y comentados por D. Manuel Rico y Sinobas*, Madrid 1863–67, vol. II, p. 6. It belongs to the second half of the thirteenth century.

[3]Ch. XXXIV of the Spanish translation (*Libros del saber de astronomia*, vol. I, p. 187), ch. XXX of the unpublished Hebrew translation (in Baldi, *Vite di matematici arabi con note di* M. Steinschneider, Rome 1874, p. 70, note).

[4]Ibn Yūnus, ch. V, in Caussin, p. 152. — One of these Banū Mūsā died in the month of Rabīʿ I 259 H = January 873; on them see Suter, *Die Mathematiker und Astronomen der Araber und ihre Werke*, Leipzig 1900, pp. 20–21, no. 43 (= Abhandlungen zur Geschichte der mathematischen Wissenschaften, part X; supplement to the 45th year of the Zeitschrift für Mathematik und Physik).

[5]Ibn Yūnus, ch. IV, in Caussin, p. 120. — He died about the year 310 H (922–23); see Suter, p. 45, no. 88.

[6]Ibn Yūnus, ch. V, in Caussin, p. 152. — They observed in the years 272–321 H (885–933); see Suter, pp. 49–50, no. 99.

[a]The print has «quos» for «quoque» and «tempore» for «partem»; Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part I, p. LXXII) correct both.

contemporary of al-Battānī), al-Kharaqī in his *Muntahā al-idrāk*[1], the Hebrew-Spanish Abraham bar Ḥiyya, writing in 1135[2], and his contemporary ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Khāzinī[3]; likewise Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī in the books he wrote before the *Īlkhānī Tables*[4], the Greek Chrysococces in his *Persian Tables*[5], and lastly, at the beginning of the fourteenth century, al-Jaghmīnī (as appears from pp. 264 and 265). Barhebraeus, or Abū l-Faraj, in his Syriac Astronomy written in 1279, uses round numbers, and so in places he gives the obliquity as $24^\circ$[6]; but where he wants more exact numbers he takes it as $23^\circ\ 35'$, as can easily be inferred from his computations of the right and the oblique ascensions (pp. 165–167 of the Syriac text).

Abū ʿAlī al-Ḥasan (that is, Aboul Hhassan), ch. XXIII, pp. 175 and 176, says that the obliquity varies between the limits $23^\circ\ 33'$ and $23^\circ\ 53'$; but in ch. XXIV, pp. 180–187, and in his tables, he adopted $23^\circ\ 35'$.

It should be noted that an error of two minutes in fixing the obliquity is of little consequence in the computations derived from it; for in the right ascensions it can produce a discrepancy only in the seconds of arc[7]; in the oblique ascensions the greatest difference never reaches three minutes of arc (especially since the latitudes that the Arabs had to use were always smaller than $45^\circ$); and lastly, in computing the greatest half arc of the day of the sun in the lands under Arab rule, the difference can never exceed ten seconds of an hour. Such differences could be neglected in those times.

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So that one may judge with what care the Arabs observed the greatest declination of the ecliptic, I have made a small table of the chief observations, using in my computations Bessel's formula, which for $t$ years before 1750 is

$$\varepsilon = 23^\circ\ 28'\ 18.0'' + 0.48368''\,t - 0.00000272295''\,t^2.$$

With an asterisk I mark the years of the observations that are certain; where the year is not known, I have put the epoch of the author's tables, or the year that can be assumed approximately. I have given the errors to the second; but everyone knows that these numbers cannot always be taken absolutely, since sometimes the year of the observation is not known for certain, or the Arab observer deliberately neglected the seconds[8].

[1] Laurentian codex (Orient.-Palat. 110), f. 40r (maqāla I, bāb XIV, faṣl I).

[2] *Sphaera mundi auctore Rabbi Abrahamo Hispano filio R. Haijae. Osw. Schreckenfuchsius vertit in linguam Latinam, Seb. Munsterus illustravit annotationibus.* Basel 1546, ch. X.

[3] Vatican Arabic codex 761, f. 10v and in many places.

[4] As in the *Tadhkira*, Laurentian codex (Palat.-Orient. 271), f. 38v (bāb II, faṣl IV).

[5] In Ismael Bullialdus, *Astronomia Philolaica*, Paris 1545, part II, p. 224. — Bullialdus thinks that he flourished in the first half of the thirteenth century (loc. cit., p. 213); but Krumbacher, *Geschichte der Byzantinischen Litteratur*, 2nd ed., Munich 1897, says that he lived about the year 1346.

[6] This value was known to the Greeks before Eratosthenes; the Indians always used it. — See also below, p. 161, note 3.

[7] [The greatest difference is in the octants, that is, at the right ascensions $45^\circ$, $135^\circ$, $225^\circ$, $315^\circ$, where an error of one minute in fixing the obliquity produces an error of $0.217'$ (or very nearly $13''$) in the right ascension. — Schiaparelli]

[8] The small tables that, after Lalande (I think), circulate among our writers (the most careful Houzeau and Wolf not excepted) contain errors whose origin I do not know; for they ascribe to Eratosthenes $23^\circ\ 45'\ 7''$, to al-Battānī $23^\circ\ 35'\ 41''$, to Ibn Yūnus $23^\circ\ 34'\ 26''$, to Ulugh Beg $23^\circ\ 31'\ 48''$, to Abū ʿAlī al-Ḥasan (Aboul Hhassan) $23^\circ\ 33'\ 45''$!

| *Observers* | *Place of the observation* | *Year* | *Obliquity observed* | *True (mean) obliquity* |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Eratosthenes | Alexandria | 230 BC | 23° 51′ 20″ | 23° 43′ 45.01″ |
| Hipparchus[1] | Rhodes | 130 BC | 23 51 20 | 23 42 56.62 |
| The authors of the Tested Tables[2] | Baghdad | * 829 | 23 33 | 23 35 41.16 |
| Other astronomers of the caliph al-Maʾmūn | Damascus | * 832 | 23 33 52 | 23 35 39.71 |
| Banū Mūsā | Baghdad | 860 | 23 35 | 23 35 26.32 |
| al-Battānī | al-Raqqa | 880 | 23 35 | 23 35 16.74 |
| Ibn al-Aʿlam | Baghdad? | 960 | 23 34 2 | 23 34 37.92 |
| ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Ṣūfī | Baghdad? | 965 | 23 33 45 | 23 34 35.50 |
| Abū l-Wafāʾ | Baghdad | * 987 | 23 35 | 23 34 25.46 |
| Wayjan ibn Rustam al-Kūhī[3] | Baghdad | * 988 | 23 51 1 | 23 34 24.98 |
| Ibn Yūnus | Cairo | * 1001 | 23 34 52 | 23 34 18.74 |
| Alfonsine Tables[4] | Toledo | 1250 | 23 32 29 | 23 32 19.16 |
| Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī[5] | Marāgha | 1270 | 23 30 | 23 32 9.49 |
| Ibn al-Shāṭir | Damascus | 1363 | 23 31 | 23 31 24.78 |
| Ulugh Beg | Samarqand | 1437 | 23 30 17 | 23 30 49.13 |

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The author's words, p. 12, ll. 14–24, fully confirm what I had already said in note 9, p. 5: that al-Battānī could by no means have inferred a *continuous* decrease of the obliquity of the ecliptic from the uncertain observations of the Greeks. How could he have argued it, when from Eratosthenes to Theon, that is, over an interval of about 600 years, all the Greeks always say they found 23° 51′ 20″?

I 162

To the later Arabs, who could compare many good observations with one another, the hypothesis of a continuous decrease was not unknown, although the small discrepancies could have been put down to errors of the observers and of the instruments. Indeed, we read the following in the astronomical book entitled the Sanjarī (*al-zīj al-sanjarī*), which Abū Manṣūr ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Khāzinī wrote about the year 520 H (1126)[6]: «In [fixing] the obliquity of the ecliptic there are many discrepancies, about whose cause opinions differ. The most likely of all is that they arise only from the refraction of the rays (وغالب الظنّ ان سببه انعطاف الشعاع دون سايره), so that, when the latitude of two observers is one and the same, the same obliquity appears to both. The greatest declination is 24° 0′ with the Indians, 23° 51′ with Ptolemy and Hipparchus, 23° 35′ with the authors of the Tested [Tables] and al-Battānī, 23° 33′ with some of the moderns (بعض المحدثين). Because of these discrepancies, and because of the irregularity in the motion of the fixed stars, some thought fit (ظهر لبعضهم) to posit a motion in the space between the two spheres, that of the universe and that of the fixed stars, which would complete the whole circle every 1285 (١٢٨٥) solar years, and whose poles, like the poles of the fixed stars too, would not lie on the axis of the universe; so that the poles of the signs of the zodiac would approach the equators or recede from them, and the motion of the fixed stars would be quickened or slowed, in a way that it would take too long to set out now. But since the obliquity is 23° 35′ with most [authors], we shall use this value in our reckonings, as one rightly accepted (استعملناه في الاعتبار مُسلا)». — Naṣīr

[1] Ptolemy, in the year 140, keeps the same value; his error is therefore + 10′ 10″. The error of Theon, who wrote about the year 360, is + 12′ 1″.

[2] If 23° 33′ 30″ is admitted, as some say (see p. 157, note 4), the error becomes − 2′ 11″. [*Translator:* The print refers to «p. 6, note 3»; Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part II, p. XXI) correct the reference to p. 157, note 4.]

[3] According to the passage of Ibn al-Qifṭī that Casiri, *Bibliotheca Arabico-hispana Escurialensis*, Madrid 1760–70, vol. I, p. 441, and Sédillot, in the preface to the text of Oloug Beg, pp. LII–LIII, cite. The codex of Ibn al-Qifṭī kept at Rome in the Library of the Accademia dei Lincei gives the same reading.

[4] So in many places in the *Libro de las taulas alfonsies* (*Libros del saber de astronomia*, vol. IV) and in the *Libro del quadrante para rectificar* (ibid., vol. III, pp. 296–297).

[5] According to Sédillot's note on the text of Oloug Beg, p. 63; the passage he cites is found on f. 105r of the Florence codex of these same *Īlkhānī Tables*. The first declinations (ff. 120r–121r) and the second (ff. 121v–122v) are computed with this value.

[6] Vatican Arabic codex no. 761, in the third chapter (*bāb*) of the preface, f. 10v.

al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī, in his Memorandum of what is chiefly to be remembered in astronomy[1], relates the following: «The total declination found by the ancient and by the more recent observations is not one and the same; the value the ancients found is greater than the one the more recent have measured. What a more recent observer found is sometimes taken to be less than what an earlier one found, the greatest value found not reaching 24°[2], while the least does not go below 23° 1/2 + 1/(2 × 10) [= 23° 33′][3]. Most (الجمهور) set it at 23° 1/4 + 1/3 [= 23° 35′]. Because of these discrepancies some have thought that the ecliptic moves in latitude and approaches the equator; if this were true, another sphere would have to be posited that carries the zodiac with such a motion. If the ecliptic moved, it could complete the circle; or it could not complete it, but reach a certain limit from which it would afterwards turn back. Any such limit could lie after the two falls of the ecliptic onto the equator, or at the time of the second fall, or between the two falls; and this last [in three ways, namely] after half the circle has been completed, or exactly at the half circle, or before the semicircle is completed. Lastly, the ecliptic could also not reach the space between the two falls, if it is thought to turn back either at the time of its first fall onto the equator or before it. There are, then, eight hypotheses. By the first five, the two halves of the zodiac, the northern and the southern, would exchange places, together with their properties; and by three of these [five], each half of the zodiac would [at times] fall onto each half of the equator. By the first seven hypotheses, a half of the ecliptic would coincide with the half of the equator nearest to it; whenever this happened, days and nights would be equal in all places of the earth, and the different seasons of the year would fail. By the last [that is, the eighth] hypothesis[4], however, there would follow only an increase or a decrease in the altitudes [of the sun] and in the lengths of the days and the nights».

Quṭb al-Dīn Maḥmūd al-Shīrāzī, who died in the month of Ramaḍān 710 (February 1311), says in his *al-Tuḥfa al-shāhiyya* (ff. 5v–6r) that no definite rate of decrease is found among the different values of the obliquity measured at different times.

Those who have written the history of astronomy say that in the second half of the sixteenth century some first recognized the continuous decrease of the obliquity, such as Ignazio Danti in his *Trattato dell'Astrolabio*, Florence 1569, though many others of that age called it into doubt; that Tycho Brahe (1546–1601) inferred it from the changed latitudes of the stars; and that, lastly, Euler (1707–1783) proved it by the laws of celestial mechanics.

**b**) — p. 12, ll. 27–32.

The rule for finding the **declination** of the *sun*, or of any degree of the ecliptic, follows from Ptolemy's construction, *Almag.* I, 12 (ed. Halma, vol. I, pp. 56–58). Let ε be the obliquity of the

[1] *Al-Tadhkira fī ʿilm al-hay'a*, in the fourth chapter (*faṣl*) of the second section (*bāb*), ff. 38r–39r of the codex of the Laurentian Library, which also contains the commentary of Qāḍīzāde. — A French summary of the passage is given by Carra de Vaux, *Les sphères célestes selon Nasîr-eddîn Attûsî*, at the end of P. Tannery's *Recherches sur l'histoire de l'astronomie ancienne*, Paris 1893, p. 346.

[2] The Indian astronomers always have 24°. — Qāḍīzāde remarks on this passage: «Some think that the sages of the Indians found it [24°], and that this same value was very well known in the time of Euclid, which is why [Euclid] in his book, after computing the side of the hexagon inscribed in a circle, derived the side of the pentadecagon inscribed in a circle, since 24 is the fifteenth part of the circumference». — So too Quṭb al-Dīn Maḥmūd al-Shīrāzī, *al-Tuḥfa al-shāhiyya*, f. 5v: «Some think that all the Indians agree on this value [24°], and that 24° was the obliquity in the time of Euclid; which is why he derived the side of the pentadecagon in his book, since 24 is the fifteenth part of the circumference». — Strange enough that some saw the obliquity of the ecliptic foreshadowed in the fifteenth and sixteenth propositions of the fourth book of Euclid, on inscribing regular hexagons and pentadecagons in a circle! [*Translator:* Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part II, pp. XXI–XXII) trace this story to Heron of Alexandria's commentary on Euclid, as quoted by al-Nayrīzī, and cite Proclus and, after Eudemus, Theon of Smyrna, who give the distance between the two poles as the side of the fifteen-sided polygon, 24°; the Addenda are translated with Part II.]

[3] Qāḍīzāde: «So at the time this book was written; but afterwards the author himself, with the new observations that he set up [in the city of] Marāgha, found 23° 30′, which is the least value found so far». And in fact Naṣīr al-Dīn adopted the obliquity 23° 30′ in his *Īlkhānī* tables.

[4] By which the ecliptic is thought never to coincide with the equator.

ecliptic, δ the declination of the given degree, L the longitude of the sun or of the given degree; by the well-known theorem of Menelaus Ptolemy proves

$$\frac{\text{chord } 180^\circ}{\text{chord } 2\varepsilon} = \frac{\text{chord } 180^\circ}{\text{chord } 2\delta} \times \frac{\text{chord } 2L}{\text{chord } 180^\circ}.$$

Since chord 180° is the diameter (2R), if sines are used instead of chords, there results

$$\frac{2R}{2\sin\varepsilon} = \frac{2R}{2\sin\delta} \times \frac{2\sin L}{2R},$$

whence al-Battānī's formula[1]

$$\sin\delta = \frac{\sin L \ \sin\varepsilon}{R}.$$

**c)** — p. 13, ll. 15–18.

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Nothing like this is read in Ptolemy, but it is found in Theon's *Canon*, ed. Halma, vol. I, p. 54: «For when the sun is between 1° and 90° we shall say that it is descending towards the north [*sic*, βοῤῥᾶν κατιέναι]; when between 91° and 180°, that it is descending to the south; between 181° and 270°, that it is ascending towards the south [*sic*, νότον ἀνιέναι]; between 271° and 360°, that it is ascending to the north». Likewise in the tables of the declinations of the sun, under the columns of the degrees of the ecliptic, Theon, I, 144, writes:

| | |
|---|---|
| From 0° to 90°: | Βοῤῥαῖος καταβαθμός, northern descent. |
| From 90° to 180°: | Νότιος καταβαθμός, southern descent. |
| From 180° to 270°: | Νότιος ἀναβαθμός, southern ascent. |
| From 270° to 360°: | Βοῤῥαῖος ἀναβαθμός, northern ascent. |

As in al-Battānī, we read in the *Libro de las taulas alfonsies*, ch. XX (*Libros del saber de astronomia*, vol. IV, p. 136): «et si el logar fuer de un grado fata tres signos. el sol es suuiente en septentrion. et si fuer de tres signos fata .VI. es decendiente en septentrion. et si fuer de .VI. signos fata .IX. es decendiente en mediodía. et si fuer de .IX. signos fata .XII. es suuiente en mediodía» («and if the place is from one degree to three signs, the sun is ascending in the north; and if it is from three signs to six, it is descending in the north; and if it is from six signs to nine, it is descending in the south; and if it is from nine signs to twelve, it is ascending in the south»).[a]

## On chapter 5

**a)** — pp. 13–14.

The computation of the *right ascension.* Let δ be the declination of the given degree of the ecliptic, $\alpha$ its right ascension, ε the obliquity of the ecliptic; Ptolemy, *Almag.* I, 13 (ed. Halma, vol. I, pp. 60–61), proves by the theorem of Menelaus

$$\frac{\text{chord } 2\alpha}{\text{chord } 180^\circ} = \frac{\text{chord } 2\delta}{\text{chord } (180^\circ - 2\delta)} \times \frac{\text{chord } (180^\circ - 2\varepsilon)}{\text{chord } 2\varepsilon}.$$

[1] With Ptolemy and al-Battānī the radius is of sixty parts; in our trigonometric formulas, on the other hand, $R = 1$ is taken, so that in our usage the author's rule becomes $\sin\delta = \sin L \sin\varepsilon$.

[a] Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part I, p. LXXII) add to this note that Theon's strange definitions are found also in the Astrologia of Vettius Valens, and that Julianus of Laodicea agrees with al-Battānī's usage; the Addenda are translated with Part I's front matter.

Using sines instead of chords, one derives

$$\frac{2\sin\alpha}{2R} = \frac{2\sin\delta}{2\cos\delta} \times \frac{2\cos\varepsilon}{2\sin\varepsilon},$$

whence al-Battānī's formula

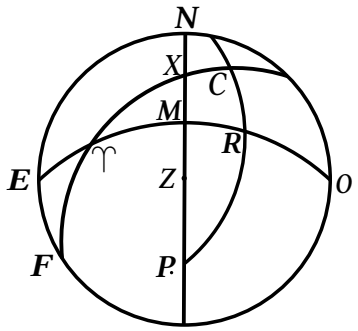
$$\sin\alpha = R\,\frac{\sin\delta\,\cos\varepsilon}{\cos\delta\,\sin\varepsilon}.$$

Ḥabash, who lived in the same age as al-Battānī, had constructed tables of tangents and cotangents (taking a radius of 60 parts), and so could teach in his work (fol. 88r), more briefly[a],

$$\sin\alpha = \frac{\mathrm{tg}\,\delta\,\,\mathrm{cotg}\,\varepsilon}{R}.$$

**b)** — p. 14, ll. 10–12.

[Now that the computation of the right ascensions of any point of the ecliptic is known, the author wants to show how the time of the culmination of those points is found, that is, the degree of the celestial equator that rises from the horizon of the given city at the time of the culmination.




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Let the celestial sphere be projected onto the plane of the horizon FENO of the given city; let P be the pole, PN the meridian, EMO the equinoctial circle, ♈ the beginning of Aries, F♈C the ecliptic, F the ascendant, C the beginning of Capricorn, PC the solstitial colure. Necessarily ♈R, that is, the arc of the celestial equator cut off between the point ♈ of the vernal equinox and the point R of the solstitial colure, is of 90 degrees; likewise the arc EM, cut off by the horizon and the meridian, must always be 90°. Clearly, then, at any time E♈ = MR. — Let X be the point of the ecliptic whose time of culmination we want to know; XC will be its longitude counted from the beginning of Capricorn, MR its right ascension from the winter solstitial colure. Since we have seen that MR equals E♈ (which is the oblique ascension corresponding to the arc ♈F of the ecliptic), the number of degrees contained in the arc MR will equal the degree of the equator then rising from the horizon; and this in all places of the earth. The computation of the arc MR, since XC is given, reduces very easily to the computation of the arc M♈ when X♈ is given, which is the problem al-Battānī solved a little before. So the author's «one and the same number» means that at any time and in any place of the earth there holds the relation

right ascension of the culminating degree X of the ecliptic, counted from the colure of Capricorn = oblique ascension of the rising degree F of the ecliptic,

[a]The print has sin α = R tg δ cotg ε; Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part II, p. XXIV) correct it to tg δ cotg ε : R, which is right when the sine and the tangents are all taken to the radius R.

that is,

90° + right ascension of the culminating degree, counted from the beginning of Aries = oblique ascension of the rising degree.

Al-Battānī's tables of right ascensions, fol. 179v–181r, therefore count the ascensions from the colure of Capricorn, not, as is the common usage of the Greeks and our own, from the beginning of Aries. In this way, to give an example, one learns at once from the tables that the end of the tenth degree of Pisces (that is, 340° from the beginning of Aries) culminates at the same time as the point of the equinoctial circle that is 71° 34′ from the vernal equinox rises. — Schiaparelli.]

Ḥabash always counts the right ascensions from the beginning of Aries, as the other Arab astronomers published so far usually do; Abū ʿAlī al-Ḥasan, however (Aboul Hhassan, ch. XXXII, pp. 218–227 and in the tables), follows al-Battānī's usage. Ibn Yūnus (on the evidence of Delambre, p. 122) made a double table of right ascensions, counting them both from the beginning of Aries and from the solstitial colure of Capricorn; and so did Ulugh Beg (Oloug Beg, p. 67 of the text, 93 of the translation, in ch. VII of the second part), who afterwards uses the ascensions counted from the winter solstitial colure in the astrological computations of the direction of the significator (p. 161 of the text, 214 of the translation) and of the projection of the rays (p. 158 of the text, 210 of the translation), in which it is more convenient to take the distances from the solstitial colure than from the equinoctial one. Tables of right ascensions beginning from the winter solstitial colure, for every minute of the ecliptic, were also constructed by ʿAbd al-Qādir ibn Muḥammad al-Fayyūmī, who died in 1022 H (1613–14); they are kept in the Cairo Library; see Suter, *Die Mathematiker und Astronomen der Araber*, p. 193, no. 479.

The oblique ascensions, on the other hand, are always counted from the beginning of Aries.[a]

## On chapter 6

**a**) — p. 17, ll. 10–11.

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Plato wrongly has 3500. — Those ancients, then, reckoned the degree of the earth's circumference at 75 miles; the 65 (in Plato 85) that are read at the end of the chapter seem to be an error, as I said on p. 19, note 8. Such a degree is of Graeco-Syrian origin. The Roman mile (1479.5 metres) contains seven *philetaerian* stadia (213.048 m), which were in very wide use in Egypt and Syria in the decline of the Roman empire. The Graeco-Syrian writers believed that the stadia of which Ptolemy gives 180,000 to the circumference of the earth were philetaerian; they therefore held that the equator of the earth contains 27,000 miles, and the degree 75 miles. Some Arabs, however, confusing the Roman miles with the Arabic ones (1973 m), took over the numbers of the Syrian writers without change. Compare what I discussed in *Il valore metrico del grado di meridiano secondo i geografi arabi*, in Guido Cora's *Cosmos*, vol. XI, Turin 1892, pp. 50–53 (= pp. 9–11 of the offprint); add that Jacob of Edessa, who died in 708 or 710, writes in his Syriac *Hexaemeron* that some make the degree 90 miles, others 75 (A. Hjelt, *Études sur l'Hexaméron de Jacques d'Édesse*, Helsingfors 1892, p. 20).

Al-Battānī does not mention the measurement of a degree of the meridian that Arab astronomers carried out in the reign of al-Ma'mūn (813–833) between the cities of Palmyra (Tadmur) and al-Raqqa, and in the plain of Sinjār (in Mesopotamia). They had found that, between about 35° and

[a] Nallino's Addenda et emendanda add to this note further tables of right ascensions counted from the beginning of Capricorn (Part I, p. LXXII: al-Khāzinī, Kūshyār ibn Labbān, al-Zarqālī, Ibn al-Musharraf, al-Akhṣāṣī; Part II, p. XVII: Theon's tables, and later Arabic manuscripts that call them «the ascensions of the culmination» or «the ascensions of the Cupola»); the Addenda are translated with the front matter of the two parts.

36° of latitude, the degree is 56 2/3 Arabic miles, that is, 111,814.67 m; their error was therefore only 877 metres. See what I wrote, loc. cit., pp. 53–63, 105–121[a] (= pp. 12–39 of the offprint).

**b**) — p. 17, l. 22.

The Indians held that the island of *Laṅkā* (Taprobane, today Ceylon), placed on the equator, occupied the middle place in the longitude of the earth; the Arabs, not rightly understanding the Indian tradition, held that the central meridian of the earth passed through an island known by no name and lying on the equator between India and Ethiopia. The place where the central meridian cuts the equator they called *qubbat al-arḍ*, «the dome of the earth», as the author says, or simply *al-qubba*, «the dome, the cupola»; whence the corrupt word *Catha* in the old Latin translation of the astrology of ʿAlī ibn Abī l-Rijāl[1].

It was also known by the name *qubbat Uzayn* (or *Azīn* ازين); for the Indians held that the first meridian of the island of Laṅkā passed through the city of *Ujjayinī*, very famous among them (Ptolemy's Ὀζήνη, today Ujjain اجين in the province of Mālwa in central India, 75° 51′ 45″ E of Greenwich, 23° 11′ 10″ N), which flourished greatly in trade in the first three centuries of the Christian era and was perhaps the chief seat of astronomical studies in India. The Arabs mostly confused *Uzayn* or *Azīn* (for, with the signs of the vowels left out as usual, ازين can be read either way) with the island of Laṅkā itself, and put it on the equator; later writers, leaving out a dot in the writing, pronounced it *Arīn* (ارين), whence *Arin*, *Arim*, *Arym* in our writers of the Middle Ages. Read the excellent discussion of Reinaud, *Introduction générale à la Géographie d'Aboulféda*, Paris 1848, pp. CCXXXVI–CCLIV; of the Arabs, al-Bīrūnī above all should be consulted (*India*, pp. 158–159 of the text, vol. I, pp. 306–308 of the English translation).

**c**) — p. 17, ll. 22–27.

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I noted already in the translation that lines 7–25 are read in the same words in al-Masʿūdī, *Prairies*, vol. I, pp. 179–181, who ascribes them to «the sages» (*al-ḥukamāʾ*); al-Battānī, on the other hand, to anonymous «ancients» (see l. 3). We shall see in note *d* that the first source of this sixth chapter is Graeco-Syrian. Our author reports what he has received, neither approving nor disapproving it, as in ch. L (pp. 120–123) on the distances and the sizes of the celestial spheres and bodies; it is strange, all the same, that he did not reject the two gross errors of these lines. [For the area of a spherical quadrilateral bounded by two parallels and two meridians is not found by multiplying the angular extent in latitude by the angular extent in longitude, since the degrees of one parallel, in linear measure, necessarily differ from the degrees of another. But even if one could compute areas as the author says, the computation would be wrong: half the circumference ought to be multiplied not by a sixth of the whole 360°, but by a third of the 180° that the latitude spans from pole to pole, so that the area found would be not 1/12 but 1/6 of the earth[2]. — The area of the spherical zone between the equator and the parallel of 60° is to the whole sphere as the sine of 60° is to the diameter; so half that zone will be to the whole sphere as the sine of 60° (that is, ½√3, or 0.8660) to twice the diameter (that is, 4, the radius being taken as 1). Instead of 0.8660 : 4, or 0.2165 : 1, those ancients found 1 : 12, or 0.0833 : 1, which is nearly three times less than the truth. — Schiaparelli.]

**d**) — pp. 17–19.

[1] *Albohazen Haly filii Abenragel, De iudiciis astrorum libri octo, doctorum aliquot virorum opera in Latinum sermonem conversi, postremo a barbarie vindicati et puritati linguae donati, per Antonium Stupam.* Basel 1571, book VIII, ch. 8, p. 374.

[2] The error is read again on p. 19, l. 21.

[a] The print has 195–121.

*The description of the seas and the lands.* — In the translation I have already pointed out, in their places, the Arab authors who drew from the same unknown source from which al-Battānī took his information; and I said that our author's passage had already been edited and translated into French by Reinaud. It remains to inquire what this common source is.

The oldest of all the Arab writers who tell such things about the seas in their books still extant today are Ibn Rusta, who wrote between the years 285 and 300 H (898–913), and Qudāma ibn Jaʿfar, who died in the year 337 H (which began on 10 July 948); al-Kharaqī, on the other hand, as we shall see below, says that he borrowed his information from al-Jayhānī (who wrote a little after 301 H, 913–14) «and other sages». All of them, therefore, belong to the age of our author. But a passage of al-Masʿūdī, *Tanbīh*, p. 51, sheds more light for us; for of the Indian sea he tells the following: «According to those who have applied themselves to measuring and depicting the earth by its places in astronomical longitudes and latitudes, the length of this sea from east to west comprises 8000 miles; its breadth to the north 2700, and [also] 1900 is said. So Ptolemy reports, and others who lived before and after him; the last who has attained these things in Islam is Yaʿqūb ibn Isḥāq al-Kindī, in his epistle on the seas and their ebb and flow, and his pupil Aḥmad ibn al-Ṭayyib in his epistle on the uses of the seas, the mountains and the rivers». Al-Masʿūdī mentions the same men in the *Prairies*, vol. I, p. 276, where he speaks of the breadth of the sea of the Byzantines[1]. In this way we reach a time before the age of al-Battānī; for al-Kindī, who had ordered a translation of Ptolemy's Geography to be made for himself[2], died about the year 260 H (which began on 26 October 873); his pupil Aḥmad ibn al-Ṭayyib al-Sarakhsī in the year 286 (which began on 16 January 899).

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Consider now that the degree of 75 miles comes from the Graeco-Syrian writers, as I showed in note *a*; add what I shall prove in the second part of this work[3], namely that unmistakable Syriac traces are to be recognized in al-Battānī's tables of the longitudes and latitudes of cities: it will not be a rash conjecture that the early Arabs received that geographical information and those measures of the seas from the Syrians. And the conjecture becomes quite certain, since in fact all these measures are found already in the famous Syriac writer Jacob of Edessa[4].

If we now ask whence the Graeco-Syrians collected all this, we can only agree with the words of al-Masʿūdī quoted above, that it takes its first origin from Ptolemy's *Geography*. Let the miles be turned into degrees, taking the degree as 75 miles and making no distinction between the degree of the meridian and the degrees of the parallels (an error which, as we saw in note *c*, those authors had already made): everything will be found to agree perfectly with Ptolemy's map. It is surprising that Reinaud[5] and Lelewel[6] not only did not recognize this but at times denied it. For the former, considering the reading of the codex that gives the Indian sea 1900 (instead of 900) miles of breadth beyond the equator, writes on p. CCLXXXIV: «Mille et neuf cents milles, à raison de soixante et quinze milles par degré, donnaient un peu plus de vingt-cinq degrés. Voilà un des motifs qui me font croire qu'Albateny n'a pas admis le système de Ptolémée, relativement à la prolongation du continent africain du côté de l'est» («Nineteen hundred miles, at seventy-five miles to the degree, gave a little more than twenty-five degrees. This is one of the reasons that make me believe that Albateny did not accept Ptolemy's system as regards the extension of

[1]Elsewhere (*Prairies*, I, p. 256), speaking again of the sea of the Byzantines, he cites al-Battānī: «Many authors of astronomical tables, among them Muḥammad ibn Jābir al-Battānī and others, say in their astronomical works that its length is 5000 miles, and that its breadth varies from 800 to 700 and 600 miles».

[2]See my *al-Ḫuwârizmî e il suo rifacimento della Geografia di Tolomeo*, p. 6, note 10 (Memorie della R. Accademia dei Lincei, Classe di scienze morali, 5th series, vol. II, 1894).

[3]I have already set this out in my little work *Le tabelle geografiche d'al-Battânî tradotte ed annotate*, Turin 1898, p. 3 (= Guido Cora's *Cosmos*, 2nd series, vol. XII, p. 163).

[4]He was born about 633 and died in 708 or 710. The geographical part is read in Syriac and in Latin in A. Hjelt, *Études sur l'Hexaméron de Jacques d'Édesse, notamment sur ses notions géographiques contenues dans le 3me Traité*, Helsingfors 1892.

[5]In the book I cited on p. 17, note 1.

[6]J. Lelewel, *Géographie du moyen âge*, Breslau 1852, vol. I: Cartes de géographes, pp. 36–38.

the African continent towards the east»). So, in drawing the picture of the world according to al-Battānī (or rather according to the ancient Greeks and Syrians whom al-Battānī copied), he makes the African coast, immediately south of the equator, turn west from the farthest peninsula of the Somalis in an almost straight line and join the coast of the Atlantic Ocean. Lelewel, vol. I, p. 37, note 86, attacks this, rightly observing, among other considerations, that to determine the breadth of the Indian Ocean is the same as to put land to the south of it; but afterwards he adds: «Mais nourrir l'idée d'une mer interne Hind, n'est pas suivre le système de Ptolémée ou copier sa carte, et je désire disculper Albateni d'une semblable accusation» («But to entertain the idea of an inner sea of India is not to follow Ptolemy's system or to copy his map, and I wish to clear Albateni of such an accusation»). And on p. 37, note 83, after reporting some of al-Battānī's measures of the seas, he remarks quite wrongly: «Comptant 75 milles au degré, ces nombres paraissent trop forts même pour le système de Ptolémée. La longueur des deux mers intérieurs [that is, the sea of the Byzantines and the Indian sea], 5000 et 8000, ferait évaluer la longueur de l'habitable sur le grand cercle à 185 1/3 degrés [*sic*, but 13000 : 75 = 173 1/3], à quoi il faudrait ajouter quelques degrés de plus. Pour adapter ces nombres à la carte ptoléméenne, il faudrait compter au moins 80 milles au degré du grand cercle» («Counting 75 miles to the degree, these numbers seem too large even for Ptolemy's system. The length of the two inner seas, 5000 and 8000, would put the length of the inhabited land on the great circle at 185 1/3 degrees, to which some degrees more would have to be added. To fit these numbers to Ptolemy's map one would have to count at least 80 miles to the degree of the great circle»). An error of arithmetical division, then, was perhaps the chief reason why Lelewel denied the Ptolemaic origin of this chapter of al-Battānī; a lesser reason was that at that time the Arabic and Syriac writers who give the same measures were not known.

To show better all I have said of the common, and Ptolemaic, origin of the descriptions of the seas, and so as to be able to correct our author's numbers here and there, I shall now give a survey of the measures reported by al-Battānī (with whom Ibn Rusta agrees), by al-Jayhānī (according to al-Kharaqī) and by Jacob of Edessa, comparing the other Arab writers too[1].

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[1]The fragments read in Qudāma, pp. 230–231, correspond to p. 17, ll. 29–33 (as far as the number 200), p. 18, ll. 9–16 and 20–24 (leaving out the miles of the circuit of the islands), and p. 19, ll. 2–4, of my translation of al-Battānī.

| | *al-Battānī and Ibn Rusta* | *al-Ǧayhānī in al-Kharaqī* | *Ǧacob of Edessa* |
|---|---|---|---|
| **The inhabited land**: | | | |
| length | 13,500 [= 180°] | 13,500 | 13,500 |
| breadth | . . . . [= 60°] | . . . . | . . . . [= 60°] |
| **The sea of the Indians**[1]: | | | |
| length | 8000 [= 106° 2/3] | 8000 | 8000 |
| whole breadth | 2700 [= 36°] | 2700 | 2700 |
| of which south of the equator | 1900 [= 25° 1/3] | 1700 | 900 [= 12°] |
| **The Barbarian Gulf**[2]: | | | |
| length | 500 [= 6° 2/3] | 500 | . . . . |
| breadth | 100 [= 1° 1/3] | 100 | . . . . |
| **The sea of al-Qulzum**[3]: | | | |
| length | 1400 [= 18° 2/3] | 1400 | 1400 |
| breadth at the end | 200 [= 2° 2/3] | 200 | 200 |
| breadth at the beginning | 700 [= 9° 1/3] | 700 | 400 [= 5° 1/3] |
| **The sea of al-Baṣra**[4]: | | | |
| length | 1400 [= 18° 2/3] | 1400 | 1400 |
| breadth at the beginning | 500 [= 6° 2/3] | 500 | 700 [= 9° 1/3] (both) |
| breadth on the direct course | 150 [= 2°] | 150 | |
| **The land between the sea of al-Qulzum and the Persian Gulf**: | | | |
| length | 1500 [= 20°] | 1500 | . . . . |
| **The Green Gulf**: | | | |
| length | 1500 [= 20°] | 1500 | . . . . |
| **The sea of the Byzantines and of Egypt**[5]: | | | |
| length | 5000 [= 66° 2/3] | 5000 | 5000 |
| breadth | 600 [= 8°] | 600 | |
| | 700 [= 9° 1/3] | 700 | 400 [= 5° 1/3] (all three) |
| | 800 [= 10° 2/3] | 800 | |
| **The Adriatic Gulf**: | | | |
| length | 500 [= 6° 2/3] | 500 | . . . . |
| **The Gulf of Narbonne**: | | | |
| length | 200 [= 2° 2/3] | 200 | . . . . |
| **The Pontus**[6]: | | | |
| length | 1060 [= 14° 2/15] | 1300 | 1300 [= 17° 1/3] |
| breadth | 300 [= 4°] | 300 | 300 |
| **The Maeotic Lake**[7]: | | | |
| length | 300 [= 4°] | 300 | a little smaller |
| breadth | 100 [= 1° 1/3] | 100 | than the Pontus (both) |
| **The strait of Constantinople**: | | | |
| breadth | 3 | 3 | . . . . |
| **The sea of Jurǧān**[8]: | | | |
| length | 800 [= 10° 2/3] | 800 | 1800 [= 24°] |
| breadth | 600 [= 8°] | 600 | 600 |

Of the two islands of the sea of Jurjān (the Caspian), unknown to Ptolemy, Jacob of Edessa, p. LXV, has the following: «Quo in mari, quia identidem multitudine aquarum, quae perpetuo infunduntur, nimis augetur, fieri non potuit ut insulae exstiterint. Vix enim ab antiquissimis temporibus usque ad hoc tempus duae solae insulae parvae ibi conspectae sunt, quae ad habitandum parum sunt aptae» («In this sea, because it is again and again greatly increased by the mass of the waters that pour into it continually, it has not been possible for islands to arise. For from the most ancient times down to the present hardly two small islands have been seen there, and they are little fit for habitation»). See what al-Masʿūdī, *Prairies*, II, 26; *Tanbīh*, p. 60; Aboulféda, pp. 47 ff. (text), etc., relate of volcanic islands in this sea.

| | *al-Battānī and Ibn Rusta* | *al-Ǧayhānī in al-Kharaqī* | *Ǧacob of Edessa* |
|---|---|---|---|
| In the **Indian sea** there are islands[9] | 1370 | 1370 | 1378 |
| of which around Taprobane | 59[10a] | 19 | 19 |
| The circuit of **Taprobane** | 3000 miles | 3000 | 4000 |

The circuits of the islands of Cyrnos, Sardinia, Cyprus, Sicily and Crete are read as in al-Battānī in the Astronomy of Barhebraeus, p. 135 of the text, except only that the 350 miles of Cyprus are wrongly given to Cyrnos, and the 200 of Cyrnos to Cyprus.

I shall now give the whole unpublished passage of al-Kharaqī that describes the seas[11].[b]

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[1]Ibn Rusta, Qudāma and al-Masʿūdī, as I said on p. 17, note 4, confirm al-Battānī's numbers; the 1700 of al-Kharaqī is a copyist's error (سبع 7 for تسع 9) that is very frequent in Arabic manuscripts. The Arabic source (al-Kindī?), then, already had 1900; but the true and oldest reading is 900, as appears from Ptolemy's map and from Jacob of Edessa («in latitudinem circa 900 milliaria a loco aequinoctiali meridiem versus irrumpit usque ad terram a terminis eius australibus versus meridiem sitam, quae ab hominibus incognita appellatur et prorsus inhabitabilis est», «in breadth it breaks in about 900 miles from the equinoctial towards the south, as far as the land that lies to the south of its southern borders, which is called unknown to men and is wholly uninhabitable»; Hjelt, *L'Examéron*, p. LXVI). See the passage of al-Masʿūdī, *Tanbīh*, p. 51, quoted above (p. 166).

[2]It is Ptolemy's Βαρβαρικὸν πέλαγος, but with these Arabs it seems to denote the Gulf of Aden. Ptolemy calls Βαρβαρία the coasts that stretch from Cape Guardafui to the island of Zanzibar. — The same numbers in al-Masʿūdī, *Prairies*, I, 231, and in Barhebraeus, p. 135 of the text.

[3]The breadth of 700 miles is also in Ibn Rusta and in al-Masʿūdī, *Prairies*, I, 237; it is therefore the reading of the ancient Arabic source. But Jacob of Edessa and Barhebraeus (loc. cit.) have 400, more correctly. — On this sea see note *e*.

[4]Ibn Rusta has the same numbers; and al-Masʿūdī, *Prairies*, I, 238, writes: «the length of this gulf is 1400 miles; its breadth at the beginning 500, but at times the breadth of its two extremities becomes 150 miles». But «of its two extremities» (طرفيه) is plainly a scribal error for the original «of its direct course» (طريقه) that is read in al-Battānī. The same error occurs in another passage of al-Masʿūdī; see note *e*.

[5]The same numbers in Ibn Rusta; al-Masʿūdī, *Tanbīh*, pp. 56–57; Barhebraeus, p. 135 of the text. In the *Prairies*, I, 256, we read: «Many authors of astronomical tables, among them Muḥammad ibn Jābir al-Battānī and others, say in their books on the stars that its length is 5000 miles, and that its breadth varies from 800 to 700 and 600». Al-Masʿūdī himself, on the other hand, *Prairies*, I, 276 (see *Tanbīh*, p. 56), reports the same numbers as Jacob of Edessa, on the authority of al-Kindī and of Aḥmad ibn al-Ṭayyib al-Sarakhsī.

[6]The length 1060 is an error; Ibn Rusta, al-Masʿūdī (*Tanbīh*, p. 66) and Barhebraeus (p. 137 of the text) have 1300, like al-Kharaqī and Jacob. In al-Masʿūdī, *Prairies*, I, 260, the length 1100 is an evident scribal error for 1300. — See p. 18, note 12.

[7]The same numbers in al-Masʿūdī, *Tanbīh*, p. 67.

[8]The same numbers in al-Masʿūdī, *Prairies*, I, 263, and *Tanbīh*, p. 60.

[9]Ibn Rusta and Barhebraeus (p. 136 of the text) also have 1370; but Jacob of Edessa's 1378 is Ptolemy's number (*Geography*, VII, 4, 11).

[10]The true reading is 19, as I said on p. 18, note 5.

[11]It is ch. II (*bāb*) of the second treatise (*maqāla*); Paris codex ff. 74r–76r, Laurentian codex ff. 57v–58v. — The author died in the city of Merv in the year 533 H (which began on 7 September 1138).

[a]The print has no call for Nallino's note 5; it belongs to the 59 of al-Battānī.

[b]Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part II, pp. XXII–XXIII) add to pp. 167–175 the like descriptions of the seas by Niẓām al-Dīn al-Naysābūrī and Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī; they are translated with Part II.

«Chapter II: on the description of the seas and their position in the inhabited lands. Al-Jayhānī and other sages [versed] in the knowledge of the position and the extent of the seas relate that there are five known seas: the first, *the sea of the Indians*, also called *the sea of China*; the second, *the sea of the West* (*baḥr al-maghrib*); the third, *the sea of Syria, of the Byzantines and of Egypt*; the fourth, *the Pontus* (*bunṭus*); the fifth, *the sea of Jurjān* (that is, *the Caspian*). — *The length of the sea of the Indians* stretches from west to east, from the farthest part of *Ethiopia* (*arḍ al-ḥabasha*) to the farthest land of the *Indians* and the *Chinese*, and comprises 8000 miles; its breadth is 2700 miles, and it passes the line of the equator by 1700 miles. A gulf goes out of it near *Ethiopia* and stretches towards *al-Barbar*; it is called *the Barbarian Gulf*; its length is 500 miles, the breadth of its extremity[1] 100. — Out of it [the sea of the Indians] another gulf too goes out towards *Ayla*, namely *the sea of al-Qulzum*, whose length comprises 1400 miles, its breadth at its beginning 700, and its end towards the nearest extremity, which is called *the Green Sea*, 200[2]; at its almost pointed extremity is [the city of] *al-Qulzum*, from which the sea took its name; to the east of it is the land of *al-Yaman* and *ʿAdan*, to the south *Ethiopia*. — A gulf also goes out of it [the Indian sea] towards the land of *Persia* (*fāris*), called *the Persian Gulf*, or *the sea of al-Baṣra and of Persia*, on whose eastern [shore] are *Tīz* and [the province of] *Mukrān*, on the western ….. [3] *ʿUmān*; its length is 1400 miles, its breadth at its beginning 500, on the direct course 150. Between these two gulfs, that is, of *Ayla* and of *Persia*, are the land of *al-Ḥijāz*, *al-Yaman* and the other regions of the *Arabs*, 1500 miles in extent. — Another gulf too goes out towards the farthest lands of the *Indians*, which near its end is called *the Red Gulf*[4], and whose length is 1500 miles. — In this *sea of the Indians* there are 1370 islands, inhabited or deserted, among which is a great island at the far end of the sea, facing the land of the *Indians* from the east, near the region of *China*, called *Taprobane* or *Sarandīb*; it has a circuit of 3000 miles; in it are high mountains and many rivers; from it[5] come rubies and sapphires. Around it are 19 inhabited islands, rich in cities and villages; among the islands of this sea are the islands of *al-Zābij*[6], the islands of *al-Dībaḥāt*[7] and *Qumayr*[8], the island of *Kalah*[9], from which tin (الرصاص القلعي) is brought, and the island of *Sarbuza*[10], from which camphor comes. I 171

[1]The manuscripts have طرفه, but without doubt طريقه, «of its direct course», should be read, as in al-Battānī.

[2]On this passage see note *e*, pp. 175–177.

[3]I do not know how to correct the corrupt words of the manuscripts.

[4]So the manuscripts, with which one might compare the Greek name of the Indian Ocean (Ἐρυθρὰ θάλασσα, the Red Sea); but why a small gulf should have taken the name of the whole sea is not understood. When al-Battānī (p. 18, l. 4 and note 2) and Ibn Rusta are compared, there can hardly be a doubt that الاحمر, «red», is an error of the manuscripts, or of the author himself, for الاخضر, «green». [*Translator:* Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part II, p. XXIII) note that Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī rightly calls this gulf the Green Gulf, al-khalīj al-akhḍar.]

[5]So the manuscripts, ومنها يخرج, rightly; al-Battānī leaves out the و, so that the pronoun must refer to the mountains and rivers.

[6]It is the island we call *Java* (in Malay *Jāwa* جاو, among the Arabs of the thirteenth century *Jāwah*); see Van der Lith's discussion in *Le livre des merveilles de l'Inde par le capitaine Bozorg fils de Chahriyâr, texte arabe et traduction française par P. A. Van der Lith et M. Devic*, Leiden 1883, pp. 231–33.

[7]The manuscripts are without dots; others read *al-Dībajāt* (ج j for ح ḥ). The name arose from the Indian *dvīpa*, that is, island; it denotes the islands we call today the *Laccadives* and the *Maldives* (*Dībat al-maḥal* among the Arabs of the fourteenth century); see Van der Lith, 216–17.

[8]I keep the reading of manuscript L (قمير); P has قمر. The name is also found written so in al-Bīrūnī, *India*, p. 103 of the text (= I, 210 of the translation), where without doubt it denotes the same region that the other Arabs call قمار *Qumār* (that is, *Cambodia*, whose ancient inhabitants were the *Khmēr*). The passage of al-Bīrūnī, which Sachau did not quite rightly understand, was better interpreted by de Goeje in his translation of Ibn Khurradādhbih, p. 50, note 1.

[9]It is the port called today *Kēdā* (*Quedah*), in the Malay peninsula (Malāka ملاك), as Van der Lith has shown, pp. 255–264; see also Ibn Rusta, p. 88, and al-Masʿūdī, *Tanbīh*, p. 61.

[10]It was a village or region in the island of Sumatra, on the banks of the river *Mūsī*, near the place where the city of *Palembang* (فلمبغ) now stands; in the Chinese annals it is called *Sam-bo-tsai*. See Van der Lith, pp. 247–253 (and 102, 105, 111, 124, 158–160, 165, 176, 190); al-Masʿūdī, *Tanbīh*, p. 61; *Prairies*, I, 243 (where the name is corrupted to *Serīra* سريرة for سريزة); Yāqūt, I, 61, III, 68 and 354; Aboulféda, pp. 22, 368, 375 (= II, 26, III, 126 and 132 of the translation), where it is always *Serīra*; al-Dimashqī, pp. 22, 199, 204 (*Serīra*), etc.

«*The sea of the West*, which is also called *the Encircling sea* and by the Greeks *Oceanus*, is joined to the *sea of the Indians*, and nothing of it is known except the part which, lying in the west and the north, faces the land of the *Russians* (*al-rūs*) and of the *Slavs* (*al-ṣaqāliba*)[1]. Beginning from its last limit in the south, it faces the *land of the Blacks* (*arḍ al-sūdān*) and passes along the borders of *Farthest al-Sūs*[2], *Tangier* (*Ṭanja*), *Tāhart*[3], *Spain*, *al-Ǧalāliqa*[4] and the *Slavs*[5] as far as *Britain* (*al-Barṭāniya*); then from there it stretches, beyond impassable mountains and uninhabited lands, towards the *sea of the East*. This sea, *Oceanus*, is not furrowed by ships and is sailed only near its shores; in it are six islands facing the land of the *Ethiopians*, which are called the *Eternal* (*al-khālidāt*) or the *Fortunate* (*al-suʿadāʾ*). Another island, called *Gadira*, lies opposite *Spain*, near the *gulf* that goes out of this sea; the gulf is 7 miles wide where it goes out, lies between *Spain* and *Tangier*, and was [anciently] called the *Ford of Hercules* (*maʿbarat Hiraqlas*); today it is called *al-Zuqāq* [that is, the narrow lane]; this gulf flows into the *sea of the Byzantines and of Syria*. In the northern stretch of *Oceanus* are the 12 islands of *Britain*. Out of it too, in the north of the *Slavs*, arises a great gulf, which is also called the *sea of the Varangians* (*warank*), after the people that inhabits its shores[6]; it stretches to the land of the Muslim *Bulgars* (*bulghār*), and extends 300 miles in length from east to west and 100 in breadth.

«*The sea of the Byzantines, of Africa, of Egypt and of Syria*, proceeding eastwards from the gulf that goes out of the *sea of the West* as far as *Tyre* and *Sidon*, has a length of 5000 miles, a breadth in one place of 600, in another of 700, in another of 800. A gulf goes out of it which, going northwards near *Rome*, extends 500 miles in length and is called *Adrias*[7]. Another gulf goes out towards the land of *Narbonne*; it has a length of 200 miles. In this sea there are 162 inhabited islands, of which 5[8] are large, namely *Rhodes*, *Cyprus*, *Samos*, *Sicily* and *Crete*.

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«*The Pontus* is called the land-locked (that is, inner) *sea*, and [also] *the sea of Trebizond*, after a port on its shore; it stretches from *Lādhiqa* beyond *Constantinople*, into the land of the *Russians* and the *Slavs*; it has a length of 1300 miles and a breadth of 300. Into this sea flows the river called *Tanais*, which runs from the northern side with respect to the *Maeotic sea*, which is the *sea of the Varangians* (*warank*)[9]. From the *Pontus*, near the walls of *Constantinople*, a gulf goes out like a river[10] and flows down into the *sea of Egypt*; near *Constantinople*, which is on its western

[1]By this name the Arab writers denote the Slavs and many Germanic tribes; see G. Jacob, *Studien in arabischen Geographen*, Berlin 1891–92, part I, p. 17.

[2]*Farthest al-Sūs* is the southern province of the empire of Morocco, whose chief city today is *Tārūdānt*.

[3]It was the name of two great cities five Arabic miles (about ten km) apart, of which one had the surname «the old» (*al-qadīma*), the other «the new» (*ḥadītha*). The former is called *Tiharet* (*Tiyāret*) on our maps, the other *Tāqdemt*; both are in western Algeria. Read de Goeje's discussion, *Specimen e litteris orientalibus exhibens descriptionem al-Magribi sumtam e Libro Regionum al-Ǧaʿqubii*, Leiden 1860, pp. 103 ff., and later in *Description de l'Afrique et de l'Espagne par Edrisi*, Leiden 1866, p. 100; see also R. Basset, *Documents géographiques sur l'Afrique septentrionale traduits de l'arabe*, Paris 1898, p. 23. [*Translator:* Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part I, p. LXXIII) add J. Canal, *Tiaret, monographie ancienne et moderne*, in the Bulletin trimestriel de géographie et d'archéologie d'Oran, vol. XX, 1900, pp. 1–44.]

[4]They are the *Callaeci* of the Romans, the *Gallaeci* of the Middle Ages, whose name survives in the present province of *Galicia* (in northern Spain).

[5]See note 1.

[6]It is the Baltic Sea, whose eastern shores were inhabited in the ninth century by the *Varangians* (German *Wäringer* or *Waräger*), a Norman people. The name is uncommon in the Arab writers; Aboulféda, p. 35 (= II, 42 of the translation), testifies that he found it written only in al-Bīrūnī and in Naṣīr al-Dīn's *Tadhkira*. — What follows in al-Kharaqī, however, strangely confuses, as we shall also see below, the Baltic Sea with the Maeotic Lake (the Sea of Azov), near which the Muslim Bulgars lived, and to which the measures given in this passage without doubt belong. [*Translator:* Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part II, p. XXIII) take back «uncommon»: the name is found also in al-Naysābūrī, al-Qazwīnī and al-Dimashqī, and C. M. Frähn, *Ibn Foszlan's und anderer Araber Berichte über die Russen älterer Zeit* (St Petersburg 1823), pp. 177–204, gathered the Arabic and Persian witnesses of this sea.]

[7]With the Syrians *Adrias* (ܐܕܪܝܐܣ *adryūs*) is the Mediterranean Sea; see F. Nau, *Notice sur le livre des Trésors de Jacques de Bartela*, in the Journal Asiatique, 9th series, vol. VII, 1896, pp. 309–312 (= 26–29 of the offprint).

[8]Manuscript P has خمسون, 50; but the sense and the grammatical construction (for جزائر عظام is read afterwards) demand خمس, 5, as manuscript L, al-Battānī and Ibn Rusta have.

[9]He confuses the Baltic Sea with the Maeotic Lake, as I said on p. 171, note 6.

[10]The manuscripts have the corrupt بحرى فيه مايه نهر, which I restore with al-Battānī and Ibn Rusta to يجري كانه نهر.

shore, it has a breadth of 3 miles, and grows ever narrower until it flows into the *sea of Syria and of Egypt*. On the southern shore of this sea [*of Egypt and of the Byzantines*] are the lands of *al-Maghrib*[1] and of *Africa* as far as *Alexandria* and *Egypt*; opposite, on the northern side, lie the lands of *Spain*, of the *Byzantines* and of the *Franks* (*faranja*) as far as *Antioch*, which *Syria* and *Palestine* follow.

«*The sea of Jurjān*, or of the [*Caucasian*] *Gate*, extends 800 miles in length from west to east and 600 in breadth; it contains two islands, which were inhabited in times past. This sea is also called *the sea of Ābaskūn*, after one of its ports[2]; it then reaches to [the provinces of] *Ṭabaristān*, *al-Daylam* and *Shirwān*, [the city of] *Bāb al-Abwāb*[3], and the region of the *Alans* (*al-Lān*)[4]; then to the *Khazars* (*al-khazar*) and the mouth of the river *Itil*[5]; lastly to the regions of the *Persians*, until it reaches *Ābaskūn* again. It is called by the name of each region that it washes; in ancient times it was called *the sea of Jurjān*, today it is called *the sea of Ābaskūn* and *the sea of the Khazars*; it does not flow into any other sea.

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«These are the great seas; the rest are lakes and marshes, such as the lake of *Khwārizm* (that is, of *Chorasmia*, today the *Aral*), the lake of *Tiberias* in *Syria*, and *Īssik-kūl* near *Barsukhān*[6]. *Aristotle*[7] relates that *Oceanus* surrounds [the whole] earth like a crown; that out of it arises a gulf on the western side, at the place called the *Ford of Hercules*[8], which, entering the inhabited land, proceeds eastwards and is the *sea of Egypt, of the Byzantines, of Africa and of Syria*. On the eastern side, on the other hand, another gulf comes out of it [*Oceanus*], entering the inhabited land, which stretches westwards and is the *sea of China, of the Indians, of Persia, of al-Qulzum, of the Barbarians* (*al-Barbar*). This is what we know of the seas».

I give the Arabic text of the whole passage of al-Kharaqī after the Paris (P) and the Laurentian (L) manuscripts:

﴿الباب الثاني﴾ في ذكر البحور وكيفيّة وَضْعها من المساكن. قد حكى الجَيْهانيُّ[1] وغيره من العلماء بمواقع البحور وامتداداتها ان البحور المعروفة خمسة احدها بحر الهند وهو الذي يقال له ايضًا بحـر الصين والثاني بحر المغرب والثالث بحر الشام والروم ومصر والرابع بحر بنطس[2] والخامس بحر جرجان فاما بحر الهند فانه يمتـدّ طوله من المغرب الى المشرق

[1]The *Mauretania* of the ancients; today the empire of Morocco, Algeria and the province of Tunis.

[2]Abuskūn, Abiskūn or Aboskūn was a great sea port of the region and the city of Jurjān (whose ruins stand near Pisarak پسرك). There are two opinions on the site of the place: B. Dorn, *Caspia, Ueber die Einfälle der alten Russen in Tabaristan*, St Petersburg 1875, pp. 5, 6, 7, puts it at the mouth of the river Gurgān گرگان, not far from the village of *Gümüsh-tepeh* گومش تپه, where Mouravieff (in the first quarter of the nineteenth century) found many ruins; Melgunof, *Das südliche Ufer des kaspischen Meeres*, Leipzig 1868, pp. 62, 63, 112, 119–120, around the present mausoleum (imām-zādeh) called *Kharāb-i-shehr*, 10 km from the shore and 6 east of the town of Gez جز (in the district of Anezān of the province of Asterābād). But it is always near the place where the eastern shore of the sea turns westwards.

[3]Today *Derbent*.

[4]They are the people called today *Ossetes*.

[5]What the ancients called the *Rha*, we call the *Volga*.

[6]The names are corrupt in the manuscripts. The city is known to the older Arab geographers, such as Qudāma, p. 203 (where it is corrupted to نوشجان Nūshajān for برسخان), and al-Muqaddasī, pp. 48, 263, 275, 340; the lake, on the other hand, is unknown to them, except to Qudāma, who mentions it without a name, loc. cit. Yet the lake, which lies in eastern Turkestan, is already called *Īssik-kūl* (ايسكول, or corruptly السكول) by a Persian book of an unknown author, written in the year 372 H (which began on 26 June 982) and entitled *Ḥudūd al-ʿālam*, «the Limits of the world»; see V. Barthold, *Otčet pojezdkije v srednjuju Aziju s naučnoju cjelju, 1893–94* (Report on a journey in Central Asia undertaken for a scientific purpose in the years 1893–94), St Petersburg 1897, pp. 31–32 (= Mémoires de l'Académie Impériale des Sciences de St.-Pétersbourg, 8th series, Classe historico-philologique, vol. I, no. 4). The Turkish name means «warm lake»; it is written in various ways: *īssīq*, *issīq*, *īssīgh*, *issīgh*. Abū Saʿīd ʿAbd al-Ḥayy Gardīzī (گردیزي) describes the city of Barsukhān and the lake (*īssigh-kūl*) at length, about the year 1050, in his book *Zayn al-akhbār*; his words are given in Persian in Barthold, pp. 89–90, and in Russian translation, pp. 113–114. The name *īssīgh-kūl* is written by Muḥammad Ḥaydar in his Persian «Rashīdī History» (*Taʾrīkh-i rashīdī*), in the sixteenth century; see Barthold, p. 50.

[7]Quṭb al-Dīn Maḥmūd al-Shīrāzī also gives this whole passage of Aristotle, *al-Tuḥfa al-shāhiyya*, f. 158r.

[8]See above, p. 171, l. 12, and below, on the Arabic text, pp. 174 and 175.

من اقصى ارض الحبشة الى اقصى ارض الهند والصين يكون مقدار ذلك ثمانية آلاف ميل وعرضه الفان وسبعمائة ميــل ويجاوز خطّ الاستواء الف وسبعمائة ميل يخرج منه خليج عند ارض الحبشة ويمتدّ الى ناحيــة البربر يُسمَّي ذلك الخليج البربريّ يكون طوله مقدار خمسمائة ميل وعرض طرفه مائة ميل ويخرج منه ايضًا خليج آخَرُ نحو أَيْلةَ وهو بحر القلزم طوله الف واربعمائة ميل وعرضه في الاصل سبعمائة ميل ومنتهاه الى طرف[3] الأَذْنَى الذي يُسمَّى البحر الاخضر مقدار مائتَيْ ميل وعلى طرفه المستدقّ القلزم فلذلك سُمِّيَ بــه على شرقيّه ارض اليمــن وعدن وعلى جنوبيّه ارض الحبشة ويخرج منه خليج آخَرُ نحــو ارض فارس يُسمَّى الخليج الفارسيّ وهو بحــر البصرة وفارس الذي على شرقيّه تِيز ومُكران وعلى غربيّه *وبحاله ى حمه[4] عمان طوله الف واربعمائة ميل وعرضه في الاصل خمسمائة ميل وعرض طريقه مائة وخمسون ميــلًا وبين هذَيْن الخليجَيْن اعني خليج ايلة وخليج فارس ارض الحجاز واليمن وسائر بــلاد العرب فيما بين مسافة الف وخمسمائة ميل ويخرج منه خليج آخَرُ الى اقصى ارض الهند عند تمامــه يُسمَّى الخليج الاحمر وطوله الف وخمسمائة ميل وفي بحر الهند هذا من الجزائر العامرة وغــير العامرة الف وثلثمائة وسبعون جزيرة

1) P الجبهانى, L الجهيانى — 2) P نبطس — 3) So the manuscripts, for طرفه or الطرف — 4) So P; L وبحالهِ ى خنبه

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منها جزيرة ضَخمة في اقصى البحر مقابل ارض الهند في ناحية المشرق عند بلد الصين تُسمَّى طبروباني[1] وهي سَرَنديب يحيط بها ثلثة آلاف ميل فيها جِبال عظيمة وانهار كثيرة ومنها يخرج الياقوت الاحمر ولون السماء وحَوْلَ هذه الجزيرة تسع عشرة جزيرة عامرة فيها مدائن وقُرَى كثيرة ومن جزائر هــذا البحر جزائر الزابج وجزائر الدِّيبَجات وقُمَيْر[2] ومنها جزيرة كَلَه التي يُجْلَب منها الرَّصاص القَلْعِيّ وجزيرة سَرْبُزَة[3] التي يُجْلَب منها الكافور واما بحر المغرب فهو الذي يُسمَّى المحيط وتُسَمّيه اليونانيّون اوقيانوس ويتَّصِل به بحر الهند ولا يُعْرَف منه إلّا في ناحية المغرب والشمال عند مُحاذاة ارض الروس والصقالبة فيأخذ من اقصى المُنتَهَى في الجنوب محاذيًا لارض السودان مارًّا على حدود السوس الأَقْصَى وطنجة وتاهَرْت[4] ثمّ الاندلس والجلالقة والصقالبة الى البرطانية ثمّ يمتــدّ من هناك وراء الجبال[5] المسلوكة والاراضي غير المسكونة نحو بحر المشرق وهذا البحر اعني اوقيانوس لا يجري فيه السُّفُن وانّما يُسْلَك بالقُرْب من ساحله وفيه ستّ جزائر مقابل ارض الحبشة تُسمَّى جزائر الخالدات وتُسمَّى ايضًا جزائر السَّعَداء وجزيرة اخرى تُسمَّى غديرة[6] مقابل الاندلس عند خليج يخرج من هذا البحر وعرضه حيث يخرج سبعة اميال وهــو بين الاندلس وطنجة كان يُعْرَف بمَعْبَرَة هِرَقْلَس[7] والآن يُعْرَف بالزُّقاق وهذا الخليج ينصبّ في بحر الروم والشام وفيه اعني بحر اوقيانوس من ناحية الشمال جزائر برطانية وهي اثنتا عشرة جزيرة ويخرج منه ايضًا خليج عظيم في شمال الصقالبة يُسمَّى ايضًا بحر وَرَنْك[8] وهم امّــة على ساحله ويمتدّ هــذا الخليج الى ارض بلغــار المسلمين طوله من المشرق الى المغرب ثلثمائة ميــل وعرضه مائة ميل واما بحر الروم وافريقية ومصر والشام طوله من عنــد الخليج الذي يخرج من بحر المغرب الى ناحية المشرق ويمتدّ الى صور وصَيْداء يكون ذلك مقدار خمسة الاف ميل وعرضه في مكان ستّمائة ميل وفي مكان سبعمائة ميل وفي مكان ثمانمائة ميل ويخرج منه خليج الى ناحية الشمال قريب من الرومية يكون طوله خمسمائة ميل يُسمَّى اذريس[9] ويخرج منه خليج آخَرُ الى ارض تربُونة[10] يكون طوله مائتَيْ ميل وفي هذا البحر مائة واثنتان وستّون جزيرةً عامرةً منها خمس[11] جزائر عظام وهي جزيرة

1) P طروبانى, L طرفانى — 2) P قمر, L قمير — 3) P سريره, L سربره — 4) P وماهرت, L وباهرت — 5) So the manuscripts, but without doubt غير should be added — 6) P عديره, L عدره — 7) P بمغره مرقلس, L بمعره هرقلس. See also p. 175, note 11; Yāqūt, I, 61, l. 19, معبرة هيرَقْلَس; Qāḍīzāde, in his commentary on the first chapter of the third section of the *Tadhkira*, f. 120v, معره هرقل; Quṭb al-Dīn Maḥmūd al-Shīrāzī, *al-Tuḥfa al-shāhiyya*, f. 158r, معبره هرقلس — 8) P وربله, L وربك — 9) The manuscripts خمسون, but afterwards جزاير — 10) P ادرس, L بربريه — 11) P بربره

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رودص وقبرس وسامس وسقلية واقريطش وامّا بحر بنطس الارضيّ فإنّه يُسمَّى طرابزند[1] لأنّها فُرْضة عليه ويمتدّ من

لاذقة[2] الى خَلْفِ قسطنطينيّة في ارض الروس والصقالبة طوله مقدار الف وثلثمائة ميل وعرضه ثَلثمائة ميل ويدخل فيه النهر الذي يُسَمّي طانيس وهو يجري من ناحية الشمال من البحر الذي يُسمَّى مايطس وهو بحر وَرَنْك وينفجر من بحر بنطس عند سُوَر قسطنطينيّة خليج يجري فيه مائة[3] نهر وينصبّ في بحر مصر وعرضه عند قسطنطينيّة قدر ثلثة اميال وقسطنطينيّة هي على شاطئه الغربيّ ولا يزال يتضايق حتّى يقع في بحر الشام ومصر الذي على جنوبيّهِ بلادُ المغرب وافريقيّة الى الاسكندريّة ومصر وبحِذائه في الشمال ارض الاندلس والروم وفَرَنْجة[4] الى انطاكِيَة ويليها بلاد الشام وفِلَسْطِين وامّا بحر جُرْجان وهو بحر الباب[5] طوله من المغرب الى المشرق ثمانمائة ميل وعرضه سّتّمائة ميل وفيه جزيرتان كانتا عامرتَيْن فيما مضى من الزمان ويُعْرَف هذا البحر ببحر آبَسْكُون[6] لأنّها على فُرْضته ثمّ يمتدّ الى طبرستان والدَّيْلَم وشِرْوان وباب الابواب وناحية اللّان ثمّ الخزر على مَصَبّ نهر إتِل ثمّ ديار الفُرْس الى ان يعود الى آبسكون[7] ويُسمَّى باسم كلّ بُقْعة حاذاها كان في القديم يُعْرَف ببحر جرجان والآن ببحر آبَسْكُون[8] وببحر الخزر وليس يتَّصِل ببحر آخَرَ وهذه هي البحور العظام فامّا غيرها بُحَيْرات وبطائح كبُحَيْرة خوارزم وبحيرة طَبَرِيَّة بأرض الشام وإِسِكّول[10] بالقرب من بَرْسُخَان[9] وقد حكى ارسطاطاليس انّ بحر اوقيانوس محيط الارض بمَنْزِلة إكْليل لها وانّه ينفتح منه خليج في ناحية المغرب من الموضع المسمّى بمَعْبَرَة هِرَقْلَس[11] فيدخل الى المعمورة ماراًّ نحو المشرق وهو بحر مصر والروم وافريقيّة والشام وينفتح منه ايضًا في ناحية المشرق خليج فيدخل الى المعمورة ماراًّ نحو المغرب وهـو بحر الصين والهند وفارس والقلزم والبربر فهذا ما عرفناه من امر البحور

a

1) P طراوند, L طراوبد — 2) P لادقيه, L لاذقيه — 3) So the manuscripts; but see p. 172, note 2. — 4) P فرخه, L فرحه — 5) The manuscripts الراب — 6) P السلون, L انسكون — 7) P السكون — 8) P السلون — 9) The manuscripts والسلول[b] — 10) P برسحان, L برشخان — 11) P بمعره مرفلس, L بمعره هرقلس; see above, p. 174, note 7.

**e**) — p. 17, l. 33.

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On this *Green Sea* opinions have differed. Reinaud, loc. cit., p. CCLXXXV, note 2, writes: «En grec, mer πρασώδης, du mot πράσον, signifiant *poireau*» («In Greek, the πρασώδης sea, from the word πράσον, meaning *leek*»); clearly, then, he took it to be the *Indian Ocean*, a part of which, washing the coasts of Africa from the island of Menuthias (Zanzibar?) to the farthest east, is called ἡ Πρασώδης θάλασσα by Ptolemy (see p. 18, note 2). But «the direct course, called the Green Sea» cannot lie outside the sea of al-Qulzum itself; moreover, the author afterwards denotes the part of the sea of al-Qulzum that adjoins the Indian Ocean by the words «at the beginning», to which, following Ptolemy, he gives the enormous breadth of 700 miles[1].

The parallel passage in Ibn Rusta, p. 84, is: «and the breadth near its end in the west, that is, at its nearest extremity, which is called the *Last sea*, 200» (وعند منتهاه في المغرب اعني طرفه الادنى الذي يسمى بالبحر الاخير مائتا ميل). With a small change of letters, «its extremity» (طرفه) answers to «its direct course» (طريقه), which al-Battānī has; likewise, in Arabic writing, الاخير, «Last», differs little from الاخضر, «Green».

Qudāma, p. 230, writes: «and the breadth near its end in the west, and at the place adjoining (or: joined to) the Green Sea, 200» (وعند منتهاه في المغرب والموضع المتصل بالبحر الاخضر مائتا ميل). In the French translation of Qudāma's book, p. 174, note 2, de Goeje explains this: «Reinaud, Aboulféda,

[1]Or rather 400; see p. 168, note 3.

[a]Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part I, p. LXXIII) exchange the note numbers 9 and 10 in the thirteenth line of this page: 9 belongs to وإِسِكّول, 10 to بَرْسُخَان, as the readings of the two notes show.

[b]The print has واسلول; Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part I, p. LXXIII) correct it to والسلول.

p. 211 (comp. aussi Ibn Khaldoun *Prolég.* I, 96) dit que ce nom appartient à l'Océan Indien. Mais on l'emploie souvent aussi pour désigner l'Atlantique, et même la Méditerranée porte parfois ce nom. On pourrait croire que Kodâma a supposé avec Bâtiny [*sic*, for al-Battānī] que l'Afrique, au sud de l'Abyssinie, tournait à l'ouest et se dirigeait vers l'océan Atlantique (comp. Reinaud, Introd., p. CCLXXXVI, note 2)[1], mais la comparaison du texte avec celui d'Ibn Rosteh prouve que Kodâma n'a pas compris sa source et que c'est en réalité à l'Atlantique que le nom de mer Verte appartient ici» («Reinaud, Aboulféda, p. 211 (compare also Ibn Khaldūn, *Prolégomènes* I, 96), says that this name belongs to the Indian Ocean. But it is often used also for the Atlantic, and even the Mediterranean sometimes bears this name. One might think that Qudāma supposed with al-Battānī that Africa, south of Abyssinia, turned west and ran towards the Atlantic Ocean, but a comparison of the text with that of Ibn Rusta proves that Qudāma did not understand his source, and that it is in reality to the Atlantic that the name of Green Sea belongs here»). But how can the Atlantic Ocean be called joined or adjoining to the sea of al-Qulzum, which we today call the Red Sea? Anyone can see that de Goeje's opinion too must be wholly rejected.

Let us now consider similar passages in other writers. Al-Masʿūdī, *Prairies*, I, 237, has the following: «its length is 1400 miles; the breadth of its two extremities, which is the nearest place in its breadth, 200; the breadth in the middle, lastly, 700, which is its greatest breadth» (طوله الف واربعمائة ميل وعرض طرفيه مائتا ميل وهو اقرب المواضع في عرضه وعرضه في الوسط سبعمائة ميل وهو اكبر العرض فيه). The words «of its two extremities» (طرفيه) are a small scribal error[2] for طريقه, «of its direct course»; so al-Masʿūdī's words agree with al-Battānī. — Al-Kharaqī, fol. 74v of manuscript P = 57v of manuscript L: «its end, towards the nearest extremity, which is called the *Green Sea*, is 200 miles» (الادنى الذي يسمّى البحر الاخضر مقدار مائتي ميل (codd. طرف) ومنتهاه الى طرفه).

Quṭb al-Dīn Maḥmūd al-Shīrāzī, *al-Tuḥfa al-shāhiyya*, f. 155v: «Two hundred parasangs [= 600 miles] is the breadth of the beginning of the second gulf, which is called the Red Gulf, and whose extremity is called the Green Sea; its length towards the north is 460 parasangs [= 1380 miles]; where it becomes narrower, and that is its end, it comprises 60 parasangs [= 180 miles]» وهي عرض بالبحر الاخضر وطوله في الشمال اربعمائة وستّون فرسخًا [add. يُعْرَف] اصل الخليج الثاني ويُسمَّى الخليج الاحمر وطَرَفه وحيث يستدقّ وهو منتهاه ستّون فرسخًا. Qāḍīzāde, in his commentary on ch. I (*faṣl*) of the third section (*bāb*) of the book *al-Tadhkira*, f. 120v, says that the Red Gulf comprises 200 parasangs [= 600 miles] near its beginning (عند اصله); «afterwards it becomes narrower, until its end comes to 60 parasangs [= 180 miles]» ثمّ انّه يستدقّ الى أن يصير منتهاه ستّين فرسخًا.

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«The nearest extremity», «the nearest direct course», etc., of almost all the Arab writers can only be explained as «nearest to us»; and since both the Arab authors and the Syrians (from whom the Arabs received those notions about the seas) lived in Syria and in Mesopotamia, the part of the sea of al-Qulzum nearest to them must plainly be the northern one. Nor can «the end» be understood otherwise, since it is opposed to the beginning, that is, to the strait we call Bāb el-Mandeb. Jacob of Edessa confirms it most certainly; for he writes in the *Hexaemeron* (p. LXVI of Hjelt's translation): «in latitudinem extrema parte australi 400 fere milliaria, septentrionali vero ad ducenta aut fortasse minus patet» («in breadth it extends about 400 miles at its southern end, but at the northern up to two hundred or perhaps less»). This being so, one might think that the true reading is the one Qudāma gives, and that in this passage the name *Green Sea* belongs to the Mediterranean (as the Arabs sometimes, though rarely, say), which can rightly be called adjoining the northern end of the sea of al-Qulzum. There are, however, difficulties: it seems hardly probable that Qudāma alone kept the good reading and that all the others, even those older than Qudāma, corrupted the text; nor could one explain why the name *Green Sea* is never mentioned in the passages of these descriptions that deal with the Mediterranean.

[1] But we have already seen (note *d*, p. 167) that this conjecture of Reinaud is wholly false.

[2] The same error in the description of the sea of al-Baṣra; see note *d*, p. 168, note 4.

The true interpretation can, I think, be drawn from a passage of the Syriac astronomy of Barhebraeus, edited very recently by Nau. The author, who wrote in 1279, used the oldest Syriac authors and the Arab writers alike in describing the seas, lakes and rivers; of the Red Sea (*yamā sūmāqā*) he has the following (p. 135 of the text): «The second [gulf that arises from the Indian Ocean] is the Red Sea, which is small and extends 400 miles in length; the breadth of its extremity, which is the *yamā dh-sūph*, comprises 200 miles». This *yamā dh-sūph* ܝܡܐ ܕܣܘܦ, which is read already in the oldest Syriac translations of the Old and the New Testament, is the Hebrew name *yam sūph* adapted to the nature of the Syriac language; it means «the sea of weeds» and denotes the stretch of the Red Sea in which Pharaoh, pursuing the Israelites, perished most miserably with his men. The first Syrian who compiled that description of the seas from Ptolemy's Geography would not leave out a name most famous in the sacred traditions; but the Arab who translated the Syriac, not knowing well what plant the word *sūph* answered to, rightly rendered it, for the sense, as «*Green Sea*». — So al-Battānī's reading is the best; Qudāma's المتصل, «joined, adjoining», is an error or a false correction for المسمى, «called».[a]

[a]Nallino's Addenda et emendanda (Part II, pp. XXIII–XXIV) give a letter of de Goeje on this note, who finds Nallino's solution very ingenious but uncertain, and holds «طريقه» a corruption of «طرفه»; they are translated with Part II.